Abrsm Grade 3 Music Theory

Diploma in primary teacher education (Meru Teachers' Training College)

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Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 1:
What's New in Grade Three

Welcome to the Grade Three Music Theory Course!

Grade three is a gentle step up from grade two – but you do need to know all the material on the syllabuses for grades 1 and 2 in order to begin grade 3.

The things you need to know already are:

- Notes and rests from the semibreve (whole note) to the semiquaver (16th note)
- Bass clef and treble clef
- Time signatures 2/4, 3/4, 4/4, 2/2, 3/2, 4/2* and 3/8
- Major scales and key signatures in C, G, D*, A*, F, Bb* and Eb**
- Minor scales (harmonic, melodic* and natural**) and key signatures in A, E and D
- The degrees of the scale
- Tonic triads (e.g. the chord of C-E-G in C major)
- Interval numbers (e.g. 2nd, 3rd)

* ABRSM only, **Trinity only

ABRSM and Trinity Grade 3

In ABRSM grade three music theory, you'll extend your knowledge of the keys, to include all keys with up to four sharps or flats. This means you'll be learning 8 new keys:

- E major
- Ab major
- B minor
- G minor
- F# minor
- C minor
- C# minor
- F minor

For Trinity candidates, the new keys/scales at grade 3 are:

- Bb major
- D major
- B minor
- G minor

For both boards, you'll also learn three new time signatures:

- 6/8
- 9/8
- 12/8

You'll learn some new foreign terms and symbols, how to transpose music into a new clef, how to describe intervals in more detail, and more about triads.

Are you ready? Let's get started with grade three music theory!

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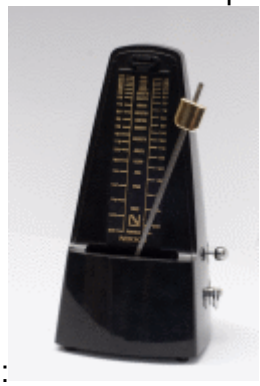
Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 2.
Notes, Symbols and Terms

Metronome Tempo Directions

Although you can use an Italian term for tempo, e.g. *allegro* or *andante*, these terms are not very exact. If you want to set an **exact** tempo, you need to use a metronome marking. This is a traditional metronome:  The rod swings from left to right and makes a loud click each time. The clicks tell you what speed to play at. The square slider on the rod can be moved up and down. If you slide it up, the clicks become slower. If you move it down, they become faster. There is a gauge on the body of the metronome which tells you what speed the rod is clicking at.

You can play with a virtual metronome at the website www.metronomeonline.com. Click the "on" button, then choose a number – that is your tempo in beats per minute. If you choose 60, the clicks will be exactly one second apart, because there are 60 seconds in a minute. Metronomes also show the Italian terms used for a certain range of tempos – you can see that *largo* is from about 42-50 beats per minute. At the beginning of a piece you might see something like = 60. This means you need to play one crotchet (quarter note) every second, or 60 per minute. Set the metronome to 60, and play a crotchet (quarter note) with every click. What if you see = 72? This means the tempo is 72 minims (half notes) per minute. Set the metronome to 72 and play a minim (half note) with each click.

If you get a question in your exam paper which asks you "what does = 72 mean?", the answer will be "the tempo is 72 minims (half notes) per minute".

Symbols

Here are some symbols which you might be tested on in the grade three music theory exam.

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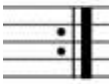
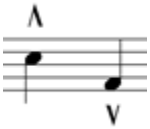
The **slur**. This curved line groups together notes which should be played in a legato way (smooth and without breaks between the notes).

The **tie**. This curved line looks exactly like a slur, but it joins together two (or more) notes which are the same pitch. It means “add the two note values together”.

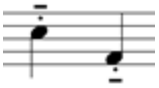


The repeat bar line. This bar line has two lines - one thin and one thick, and two dots. It means “go back to the start/ the last repeat bar line and play again”.

Forzato. “Forced” or “sharply accented”.



Marcato. Marked, or accented.



Mezzo staccato (or semi-staccato). Half staccato, half way between staccato and legato.

Foreign Terms ABRSM

Don't forget, you need to know all the terms listed for grade 1 and grade 2, as well as these!

ad libitum, ad lib.	at choice, i.e. a passage may be played freely
adagietto	rather slow, but faster than adagio
agitato	agitated
alla breve	with a minim beat (half note beat) (2/2)
amore	love
amoroso	loving

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anima	soul, spirit
animando	becoming more lively
animato	animated, lively
ben	well
brio	vigour
con	with
con anima	with feeling
deciso	with determination
delicato	delicate
energico	energetic
forza	force
largamente	broadly
leggiero	light or nimble
marcato, marc.	emphatic, accented
marziale	in a military style
mesto	sad

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pesante	heavy
prima, primo	first
prima volta	first time
risoluto	bold, strong
ritmico	rhythmically
rubato, tempo rubato	with some freedom of time
scherzando, scherzoso	playful, joking
seconda, secondo	second
seconda volta	second time
semplice	simple, plain
sempre	always
stringendo	gradually getting faster
subito	suddenly
tanto	so much
tempo comodo	at a comfortable speed
tranquillo	calm

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triste, tristamente	sad, sorrowful

Foreign Terms Trinity

dolce	sweetly
leggiero	lightly
marziale	in the style of a march
tranquillo	calmly
vivo	lively
al, alla	like, in the style of
a tempo	at the original speed
con	with
da capo al fine	go back to the start and play until the "fine" marking
e, ed	and
meno	less
mosso, moto	movement
non	not
poco	little
più	more

The Demisemiquaver (ABRSM only)

The smallest note you will have come across in grades 1 and 2 is the semiquaver. Remember that 4 semiquavers are worth 1 crotchet.

A semiquaver has two little tails on the stem, which are always on the right hand side.

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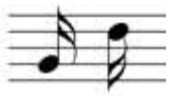
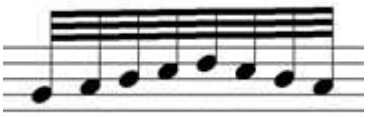


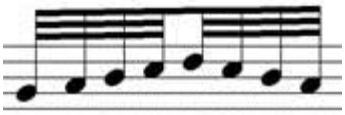
The **demi**semiquaver is worth half a semiquaver. You need 8 demisemiquavers to make up the value of 1 crotchet. A demisemiquaver has **three** little tails:

Demisemiquavers are usually grouped and beamed in **fours**:

But because we need **eight** of them to equal one crotchet, we often put two groups of four together:

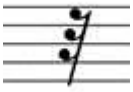


To make it easier to see the division of beats, many people prefer to use one long beam at the top, to join all the notes, and then two shorter beams on each group of four:



One semibreve is worth 32 demisemiquavers. One minim is worth 16. One crotchet is worth 8. One quaver is worth 4. One semiquaver is worth 2 demisemiquavers.

The demisemiquaver rest looks like this:



It has three tails, and each tail sits within a space on the stave.

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Grade 3 Music Theory:
Notes, Symbols and Terms Exercises (ABRSM)

Exercise 1 – Demisemiquavers

How many demisemiquavers are worth the same as

1. two semibreves
2. one minim
3. one crotchet
4. three quavers

5. Draw a demisemiquaver rest:

Exercise 2 – Musical Terms

What do these Italian terms mean in English?

Hover your cursor over the blank "English" cells to reveal the translation.

Italian	**English**	**Italian**	**English**
ad libitum (ad lib.)	at choice (played freely)	adagietto	rather slow, but faster than adagio
agitato	agitated	alla breve	with a minim (half note) beat (in 2/2)
amore	love	amoroso	loving
anima	soul/spirit	animando	becoming more lively
animato	lively/animated	ben	well
brio	vigour	con	with
con anima	with feeling	deciso	with determination
delicato	delicately	energico	energetically
forza	force	largamente	broadly
leggiero	light/nimble	marcato, marc.	emphatic/accented
marziale	in a military style	mesto	sadly
pesante	heavy	primo, prima	first

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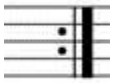
risoluto	bold/strongly	ritmico	rhythmically
rubato, tempo rubato	with freedom of time	scherzando, scherzoso	playful/joking
seconda, secondo	second	seconda volta	second time
semplice	simple/plainly	sempre	always
tanto	so much	tempo comodo	at a comfortable speed
tranquillo	calmly	triste, tristamente	sadly/sorrowful

Exercise 3 – Musical Symbols

What do these symbols mean?

a)

b) 

c)

d)

e) = 108

Exercise 1 (US Version) – Thirty-second Notes

How many thirty-second notes are worth the same as

1. two whole notes
2. one half note
3. one quarter note
4. three eighth notes

5. Draw a thirty-second rest:

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Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 3:

Scales (ABRSM)

Major Scales

You should already be familiar with the scales of C, G, D, A, F, Bb and Eb major, as these are on the syllabus for grades 1 and 2.

All major scales are built using this pattern of tones (T) (whole steps) and semitones (S) (half steps):

T-T-S-T-T-T-S.

The first new scale in grade three music theory is E major. E major has four **sharps:**

F#, C#, G# and D#.

If you look closely you'll discover that each sharp is exactly **one 5th** higher than the previous one.

Start at F(#) and count 5 notes, and you will arrive at C(#):

F, G, A, B, **C**.

Then start at C and count up 5 notes and you will arrive at G(#)

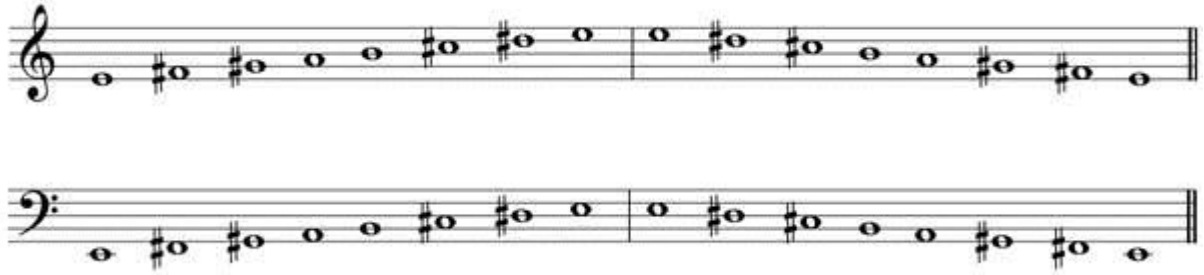
C, D, E, F, **G**.

Start at G and count up 5 notes and you arrive at D(#):

G, A, B, C, **D**.

This is an easy way to remember the order of sharps – this is the beginning of the "circle of 5ths" (because if you keep on going, you'll eventually end up back at the beginning!)

Here's the scale of E major, ascending and descending, in treble and bass clef:



The other new major scale we're going to learn is Ab major.

Ab has got four **flats** – Bb, Eb, Ab, and Db.
An easy way to remember the order of flats is to count **down** five notes from the first one.
The first flat is Bb:

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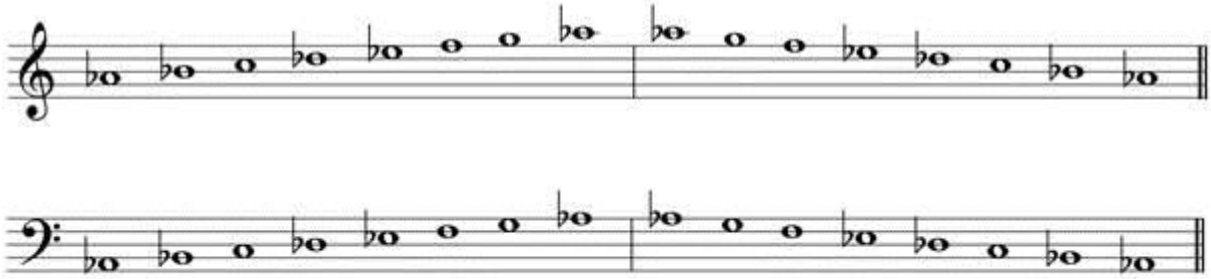
B, A, G, F, **E**.
E, D, C, B, **A**.
A, G, F, E, **D**.
The circle of 5ths works in both directions – if you count **upwards**, you get the order of sharps. If you count **downwards**, you get the order of flats!

Here is the scale of Ab major, ascending and descending in treble and bass clef:



Also, you could just learn the word "BEAD" which spells the flats in order!

Minor Scales

You should already be familiar with the minor scales in the keys of A, E and D. For grade three, you also need to know the minor scales with up to four sharps or flats in the key signature:

- B minor
- G minor
- F# minor
- C minor
- C# minor
- F minor

In grade two music theory we learnt that there are two types of minor scales, the **harmonic minor** and the **melodic minor**.

- The harmonic minor has the pattern T-S-T-T-S-3S-S (3S = 3 semitones).
- The melodic minor has one pattern on the way up and another on the way down:
  - Ascending (from bottom): T-S-T-T-T-T-S
  - Descending (from top): T-T-S-T-T-S-T

At grade two, you were given a free choice about which version of the minor scale you wanted to write. But at grade 3, you will be told which version you have to write, so you **must** learn both versions of each scale. If you find it difficult to remember all the patterns of tones and semitones, try this method instead: learn the notes of three types of minor scale for **A minor** - they are easy to learn. Then write out the A minor scale and calculate whether each step is a tone (whole step), semitone (half step) or three semitones (three half steps). Then use the same pattern as a guide, to write out a new scale in a different key.

Here are all the new minor scales you need to know for grade 3 music theory.

Notice that in F# minor and C# minor there are two notes which you might not have seen before: E# and B#. These are both **white notes** on the piano. E# is the same note on the

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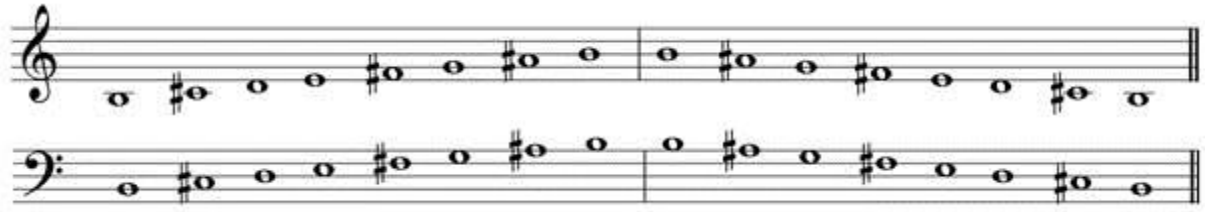
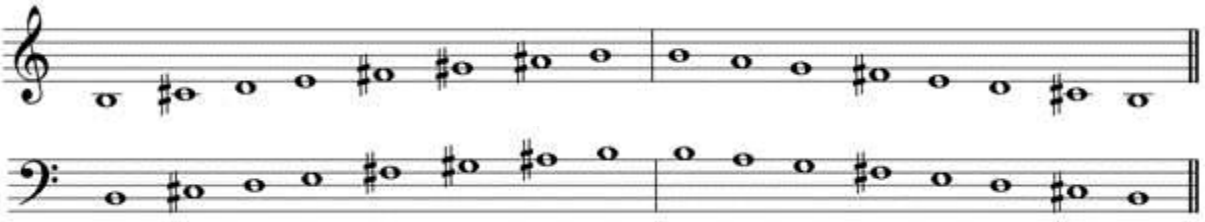
piano as F natural and B# is the same as C natural. But although they are the same note on an instrument, they are **different** notes in music theory, and you must be careful to use the correct one. Remember that in scales, you can only use each letter name **once**, apart from the first and last notes of the scale. So we use E# (and not F natural) in F# minor, because we have already used the letter "F" as the first and last notes of the scale. E# and F are called "enharmonic equivalents" (and so are B#/C and all the other notes which you are probably more familiar with, like Ab/G# or Eb/D# etc.)

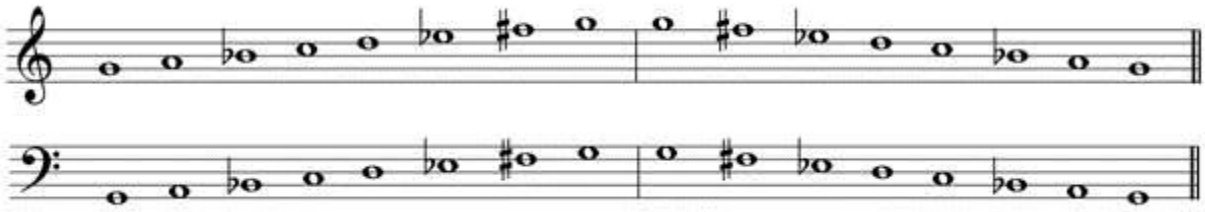
B minor harmonic



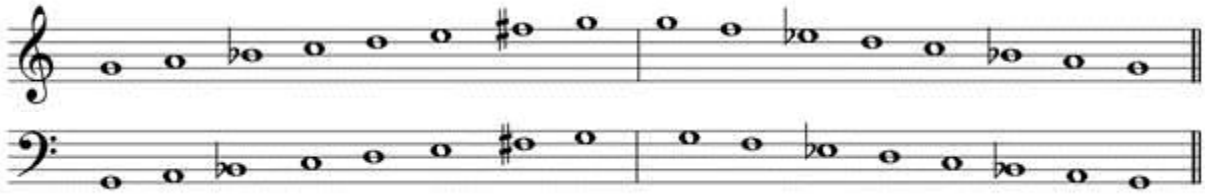
B minor melodic



G minor harmonic



G minor melodic



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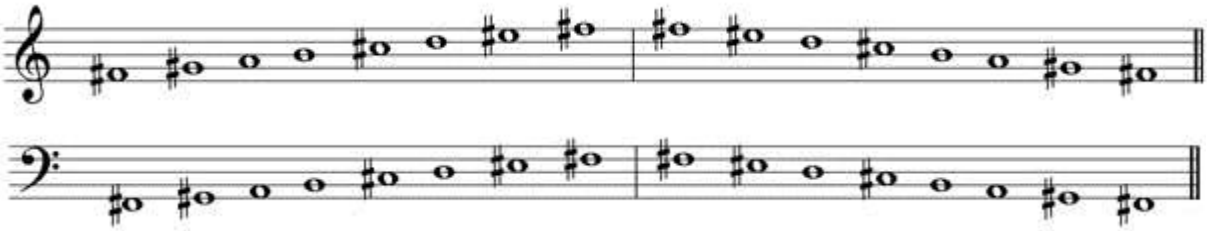
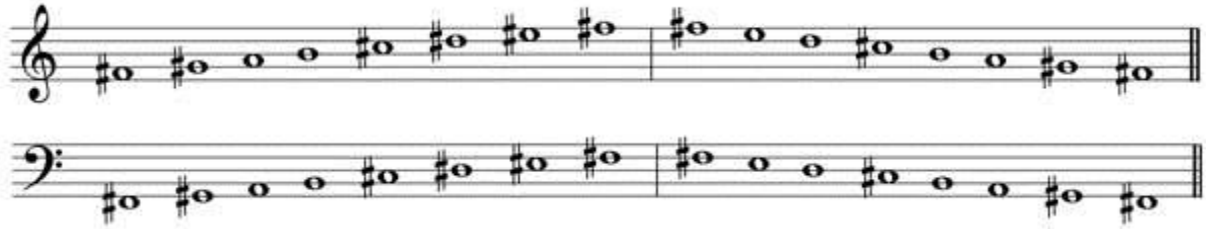
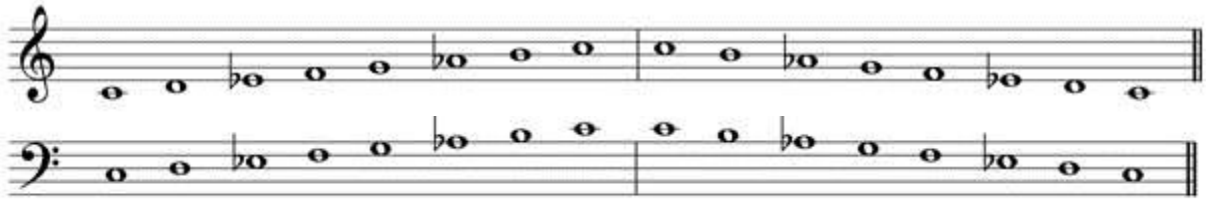
F# minor harmonic



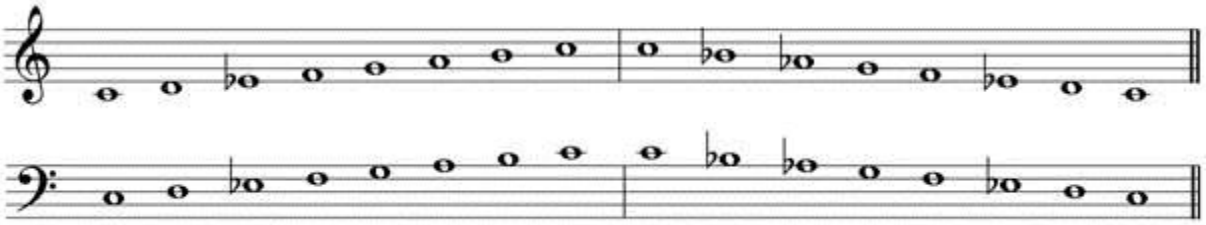
F# minor melodic



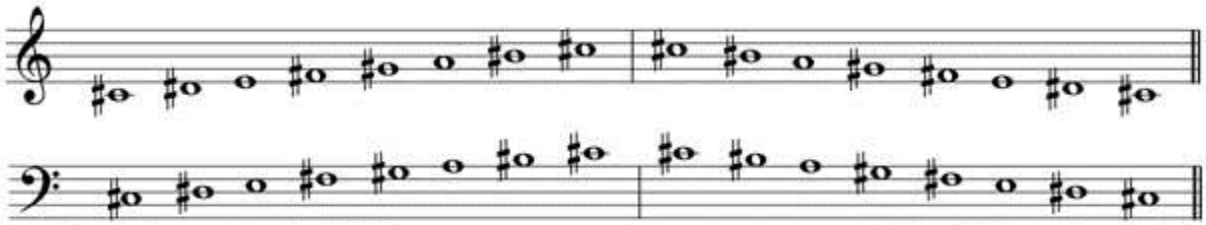
C minor harmonic



C minor melodic



C# minor harmonic



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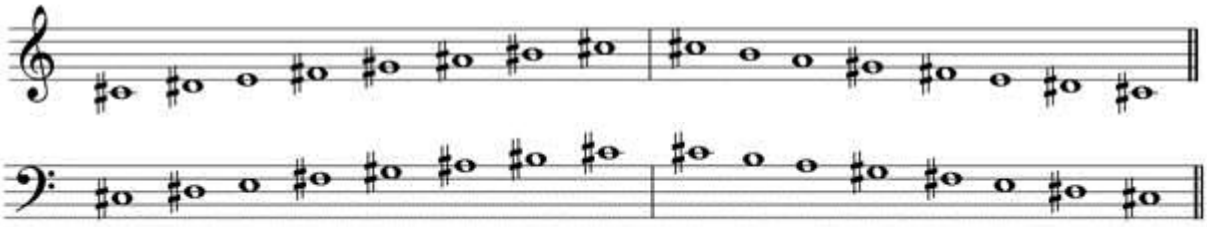
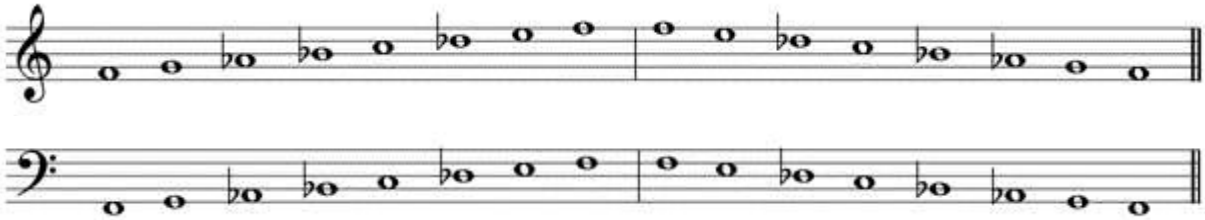
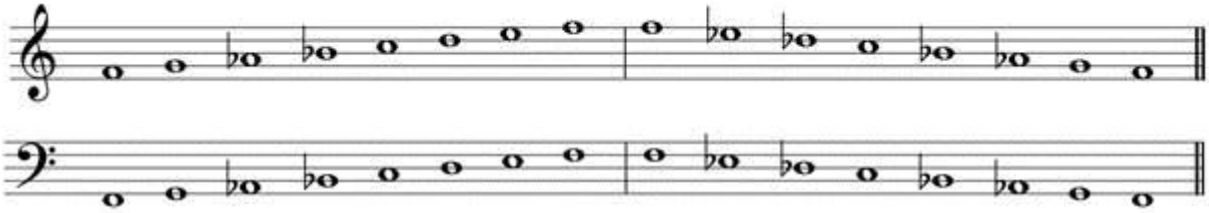
C# minor melodic



F minor harmonic



F minor melodic



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Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 3: Scales (Trinity)

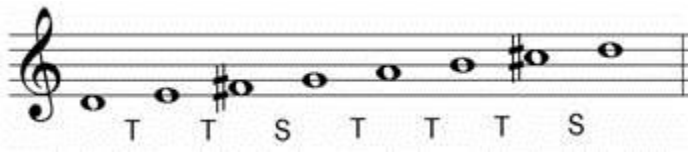
Major Scales

You should already be familiar with the scales of C, G and F major, as these are on the Trinity syllabus for grades 1 and 2.

All major scales are built using this pattern of tones (T) (whole steps) and semitones (S) (half steps):

T-T-S-T-T-T-S.

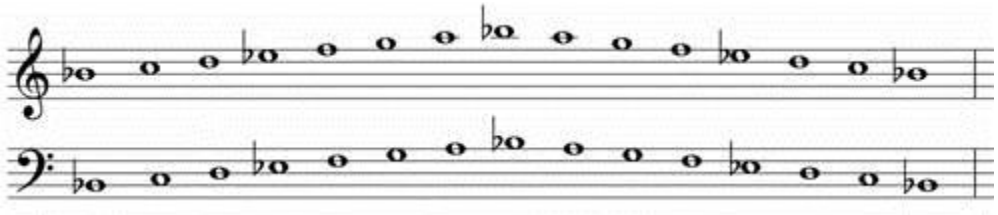
The first new scale in grade three music theory is D major. D major has two **sharps:** F# and C#.



The other new major scale we're going to learn is Bb major.

Bb has got two **flats**: Bb and Eb. Here is the scale going up, and going down, for one octave.

Don't forget, you need to know your scales in the bass clef too!



Minor Scales

You should already be familiar with the minor scales in the keys of A, E and D. For grade three, you also need to know the minor scales with **two** sharps or flats in the key signature:

- B minor
- G minor

In grade two music theory we learnt that there are two types of minor scales, the **harmonic minor** and the **natural minor**. For grade 3, we will learn a third type of minor scale – the **melodic minor**.

- The harmonic minor has the pattern T-S-T-T-S-3S-S (3S = 3 semitones).
- The natural minor has the pattern T-S-T-T-S-T-T

Don't forget, you can work out the patterns by looking at the scales of C major, or A minor. C major uses only the white notes on the piano, starting on C. A natural minor also only uses the white notes, but starting on A. The harmonic A minor scale is the same as the

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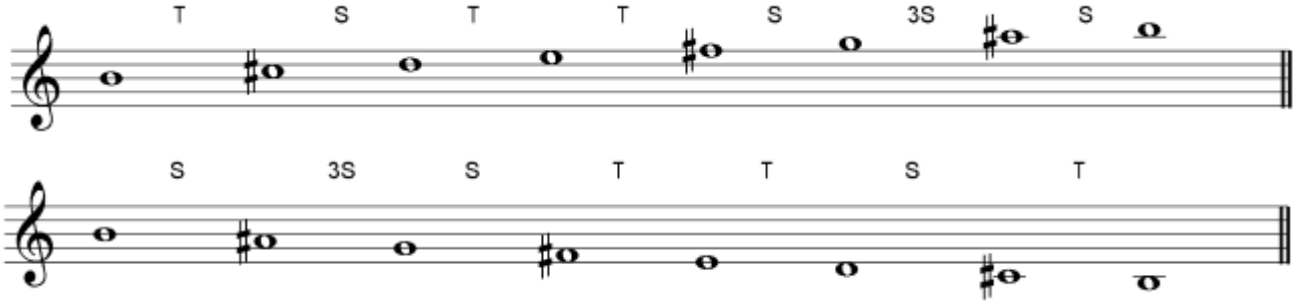
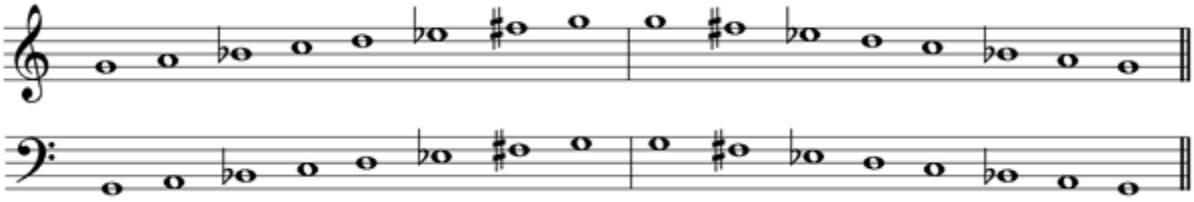
natural minor scale, except it has G# instead of G natural (one black note). Once you have figured out the pattern of tones and semitones, you can use it to work out any other scale of the same type!

Here is the scale of B minor harmonic, with the tones and semitones marked, going up and going down. B minor harmonic has C#, F# and A# in it. Notice that we use A# and not Bb – this is because we should only use each letter of the alphabet **once** in each scale (apart from the top and bottom notes).



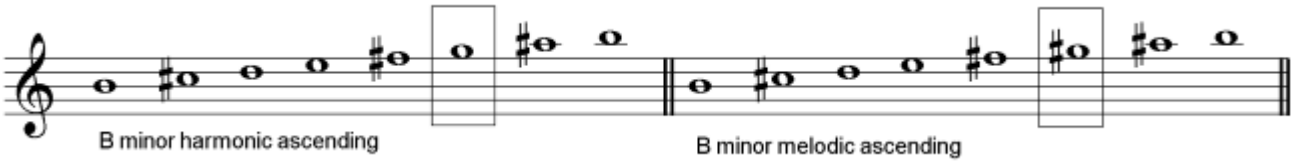
And this is the scale of G minor harmonic, in treble and bass clefs.



Melodic Minor Scales

Let's take a look at how to build a **melodic minor** scale. Melodic minor scales are quite unusual, because they use one set of notes on the way **up**, and another set of notes on the way **down**.

The ascending (rising) scale is similar to the **harmonic** minor scale. The only difference is that the **6th** note of the scale is raised by **one semitone** with an accidental. Compare B minor harmonic and melodic:



The 6th note is G natural in the harmonic minor scale, but in the melodic minor scale is it raised to G# with an accidental. Notice again that we use G# and not Ab, because we need to use each letter only once.

Here is the scale of G minor ascending, in the harmonic and melodic forms:

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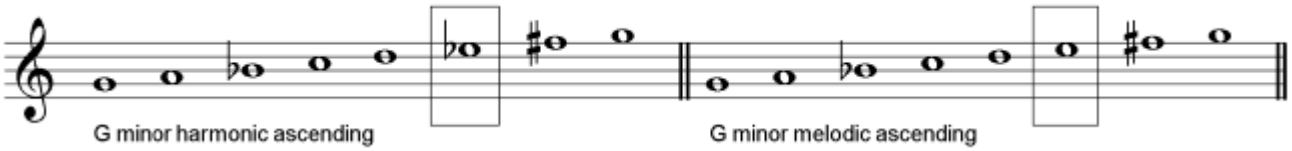
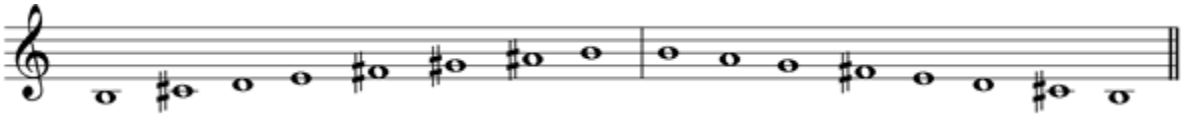
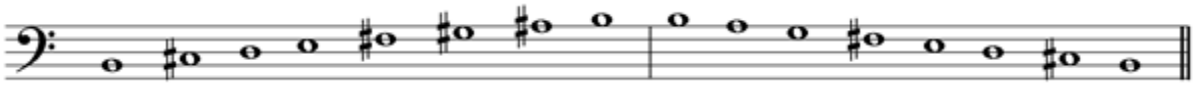


In the harmonic minor scale, the 6th note is Eb. In the melodic minor scale, this rises by one semitone to E natural. (We don't need to use an accidental in this case).

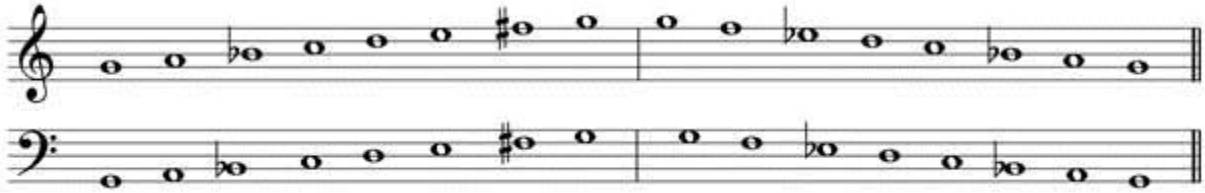
The descending (falling) melodic minor scales are **identical** to the natural minor scales going down.
Here is B melodic minor ascending and descending. Notice that on the way down, **two notes** are different from the ascending scale: the 6th and 7th degrees. Remember that when a scale is going down, the degrees of the scale will be backwards. The 6th and 7th degrees of the B minor scale are A(#) and G(#).



Here is B minor melodic in the bass clef:



And here is G minor melodic:



Do have a go at playing these scales on your instrument, if you haven't already! Pay particular attention to the changes at the top end of the melodic minor scale.

The names of "harmonic" and "melodic" minor refer to the way the scales are used in music. We tend to use the notes from the harmonic minor scale to create **harmony**, or chords. On the other hand, we use the melodic minor scale patterns within **melody**, or tunes. The natural minor scale (ascending form) is most often heard in folk and pop music, and much less often in the classical style.

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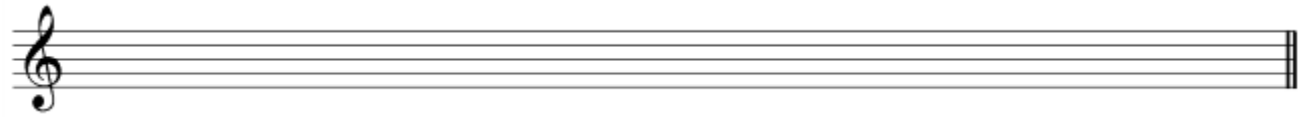
Trinity Grade 3 Scales Exercises

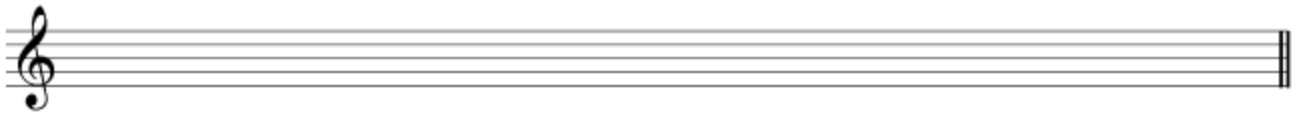
Exercise 1

Using semibreves (whole notes), write one octave of the following scales, beginning on the tonic. Do **not** use a key signature, but add any sharps or flats as necessary.

a) Bb major going up.



b) G melodic minor going down.



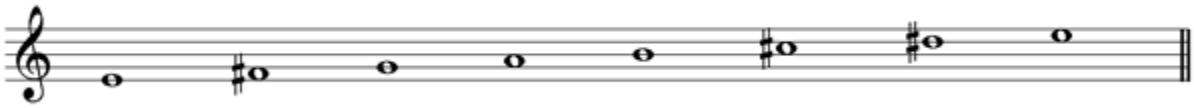
c) D major going down.

Exercise 2

Name the following scales e.g. "C major". If the scale is minor, say which type of minor (harmonic, melodic or natural) it is.

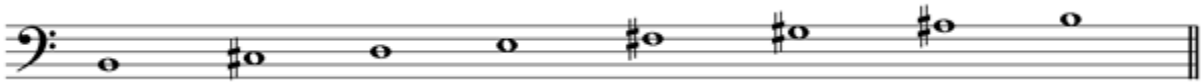
Hover over the scale to reveal the answer (tap on touch screen devices).

a)



b)

c)



For more exercises, download the Trinity Grade 3 PDF here!

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Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 4: Key Signatures

Key signatures are written after the clef and before the time signature.

Key signatures have to be written very carefully. You need to make sure the flats and sharps are written

- in the right **order**
- in the right **position**

In the grade three ABRSM music theory exam, you need to be able to write and understand key signatures with up to **4** sharps or **4** flats.
In the grade three TRINITY music theory exam, you need to be able to write and understand key signatures with up to **2** sharps or **2** flats.
(This doesn't mean the Trinity exam is easier - the Trinity exam includes things that the ABRSM doesn't. Compare the syllabuses here.)

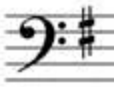
Sharp Key Signatures

The sharps, in order, are F# - C# - G# - D#.

F# is used for G major and E minor
F# and C# are used for D major and B minor
F#, C# and G# are used for A major and F# minor
F#, C#, G# and D# are used for E major and C# minor

Position of the Sharps
In the treble clef, F# is always written on the top line:

In the bass clef, it's always written on the second line from the top:



C# is written **lower** than the F#:

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G# is written **higher** than C#:

D# is written **lower** than G#:

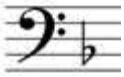
Look at the pattern: it goes down, up, down, in both clefs!

Flat Key Signatures

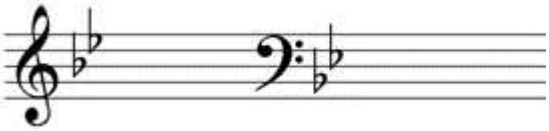
Position of the Flats

In the treble clef, Bb is written on the middle line:

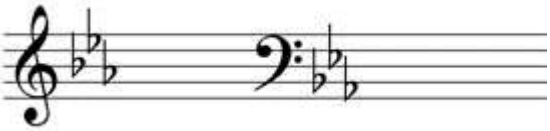
In the bass clef, it's written on the 2nd line from the bottom:



Eb is written **higher** than Bb:



Ab is written **lower** than Eb:



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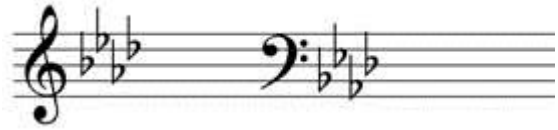
Db is written **higher** than Ab:



Look at the patterns: up, down, up, in both clefs - the opposite to the sharps' pattern!

Relative Major and Relative Minor

We say that G major is the “relative major” to E minor, and that E minor is the “relative minor” to G major, because they use the **same** key signature.
To find out what the key signature is for a **minor** key, you first need to find the key signature for its relative **major**. So if you want to find the key signature for C# minor, you need to work out what the relative major of C# minor is.

To find a relative major, count upwards **one tone (whole step) and one semitone (half step).** Make sure you count 3 **different letter names** too:
C# - D# is one tone (whole step),
D# - E is one semitone (half step).
Therefore, the relative major of C# minor is E major. It has 4 sharps.

To find out the relative minor, do the opposite – count downwards **one semitone and one tone**:
G major
G- F is one tone,
F - E is one semitone.
So, the relative minor of G major is E minor.

Key Signatures and Minor Keys

The **key signature** for a minor key includes all the sharp/flat notes from the **natural** minor scale – this is the same as the **descending melodic minor scale**.

For example, A minor melodic descending is A-G-F-E-D-C-B-A. There are no sharps and flats, so there are also no sharps or flats in the key signature for A minor.

Some students think that because A minor harmonic includes G#, there must be a G# in the key signature. This is a mistake!

When you write a minor scale **with** a key signature, you will need to add some **accidentals** (sharps and flats next to the notes) if the scale is:

- harmonic minor, ascending or descending: raise the **7th** degree of the scale by one semitone (half step).
- melodic minor ascending only (raise the **6th AND 7th** degrees of the scale by one semitone (half step).

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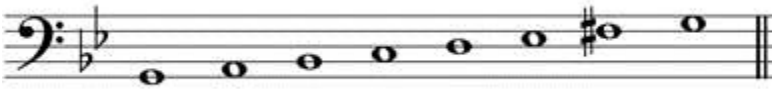
In some scales a raised note will be written with a **sharp**, in others you will need to add **naturals**, to cancel flats from the key signature.

Descending minor melodic scales should have no extra accidentals added.

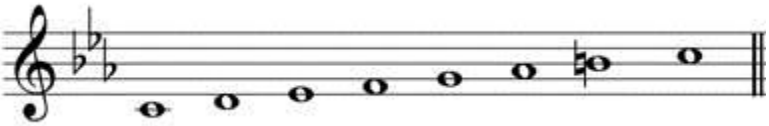
Here are some examples of minor scales with a key signature **and** accidentals:

All **harmonic** minor scales have a **raised 7th** degree of the scale.

G minor harmonic (F becomes F#)

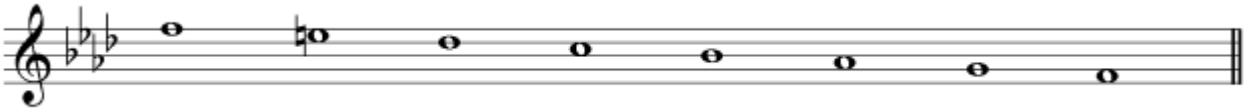


C minor harmonic (Bb becomes B natural)



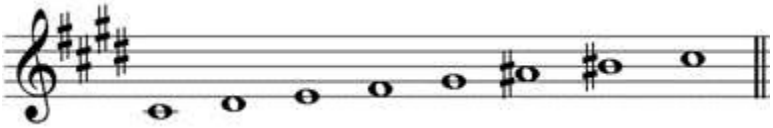
Don't forget that the degrees of the scale are worked out from the **ascending** scale, so in a descending scale the 7th degree will be at the beginning of the scale instead of the end.

For example, here is the descending scale of F minor harmonic. The 7th degree of the scale is E natural.

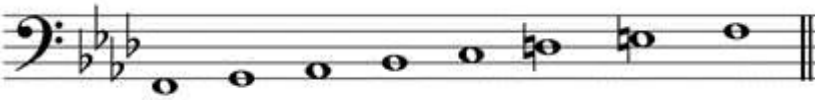


All melodic minor ascending scales have **raised 6th and 7th** degrees of the scale:

C# minor melodic ascending (A and B become A# and B#)



F minor melodic ascending (Db and Eb become D natural and E natural).



Don’t forget that in the **descending** melodic minor scale, and the natural minor scale in **both directions** do not use any extra accidentals, when a key signature is used.

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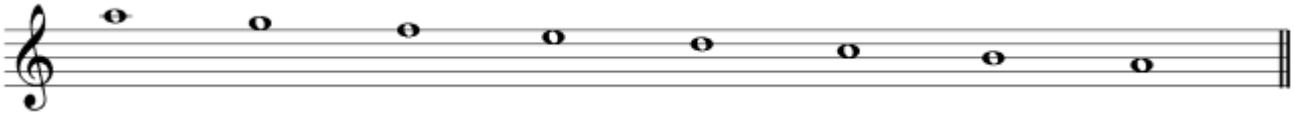
A minor melodic descending (or natural minor) (F and G natural)



E minor melodic descending (or natural minor) (C and D natural)

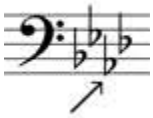
Tips

Here is a quick way to check which key a key signature represents:

- in **sharp** key signatures, the last sharp in the key signature is the **leading note** (note before the tonic). It's one semitone (half step) lower than the tonic of the major key. For example:

  The last sharp is D#. The note one semitone (half step) higher than D# is **E**. This is the key signature for E major.

- in **flat** keys, the last-but-one flat in the key signature is the **tonic** of the major key. For - example:

  The last-but-one flat is Ab. This is the key signature for Ab major.

You need to remember that F major has only one flat (because there isn't a "last-but-one flat" in F major!

For a complete list of all the major and minor scales, see our List of Musical Scales.

Working out the Key

Often, you will want to know what **key** a piece of music is in, but because each key signature stands for **two** keys (one major, and one minor), you will need to do a little bit of detective work to figure out which key it is.
After checking the key signature, there are two more places to look to find clues about the key. You need to look at the **harmony,** and the **melody**.
Harmony

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The word “harmony” means “chords”. If there are actual chords in the music, they will be a big help to you. But even if there are no chords (because the tune is just a single melody line, for example), you can look for patterns **based** on chords:

- broken chords
- arpeggios

You need to look out for the **tonic triad** of the key you think the music is in. We expect to find the tonic triads (or notes from the tonic triad):

- right at the beginning of the piece (bar 1)
- right at the end of the piece (last bar)
- used more often than other chords

Melody

The word “melody” means the “tune”. The notes used in the melody will belong to the **scale** of the key the music is in. So, a piece in C major will use the notes from the C major scale, and a piece in A minor will use notes from the A minor scale.

You will remember though, that the natural minor and descending melodic minor scales use **exactly the same notes** as the major scale:

- C major: C-D-E-F-G-A-B
- A minor (natural/melodic descending): A-B-C-D-E-F-G

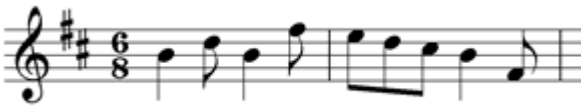
This means that if you see accidentals which belong to the ascending melodic minor scale (F# and G# in A minor), the music is probably in the minor key. But, if you see the notes without accidentals (F and G), it could be **either** key, and you will need to look for more clues.

As with the harmony, the **tonic** is the most important note in melody. You can expect to find the tonic note (also called “doh” or the “keynote”):

- In bar 1
- On a strong beat
- Used a lot
- Repeated, or accented
- Used as the start/end note of a small section of a scale
- Any combination of these

Here are some examples.

The key signature is used for D major and B minor – which key is it?



- The first bar is made up of the notes of a triad of B minor (B-D-F#).
- The note B is on the strongest beat of bar 1, and is repeated in that bar.
- There is a section of a scale leading down to B (F#-E-D-C#-B).

All of these clues lead us to the key of **B minor** for this piece.

The key signature is used for Bb major and G minor – which key is it?

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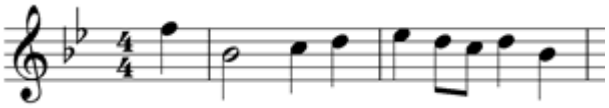
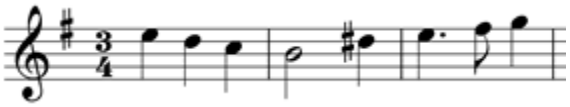


- The note on the strongest beat of bar 1 is Bb.
- Bb is the longest note at the start of the piece.
- There are no Gs in the piece so far.
- There is a section of a scale leading up from Bb (Bb-C-D-Eb).

The clues lead us to the key of **Bb major**.

The key signature is used for G major and E minor – which key is it?



- The note on the strongest beat of bar 1 is E.
- There is a section of a scale leading down from E (E-D-C-B)
- There is a D#, which is part of the E minor scale.

The clues lead us to the key of **E minor**.

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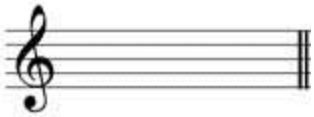
Grade 3 Music Theory: 4.
Key Signatures Exercises

Exercise 1 - Writing Key Signatures

Write out the following key signatures:

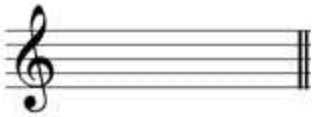
1. D minor

2. E major*



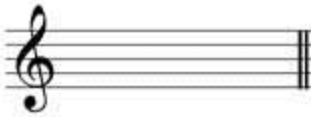
3. B minor

4. Eb major*

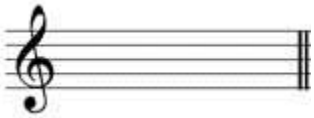


5. Bb major

6. G minor



7. C# minor*



8. A major*

9. F minor*

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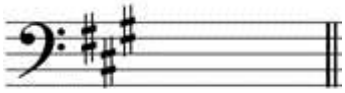
10. E minor

Exercise 2 - Relative Keys

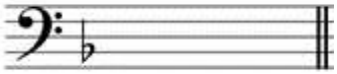
Give the two keys (relative major and minor) which belong to each of these key signatures:

a)*

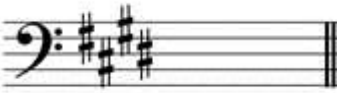


b)

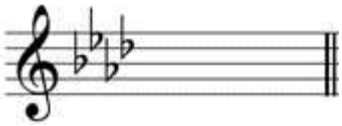
c)



d)*

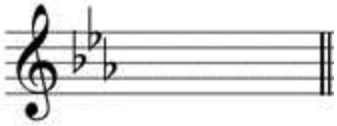


e)*



f)

g)*



h)

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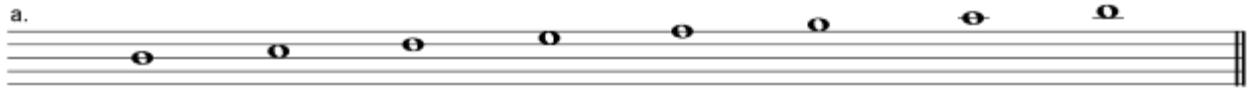
i)

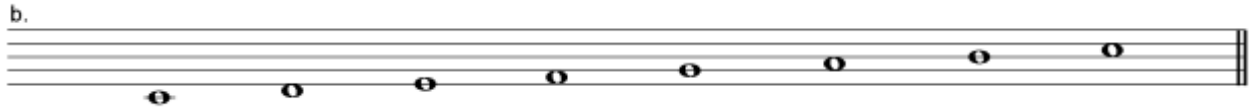
Exercise 3 - Adding a Clef & Key Signature to Scales

Add the correct clef and key signature to make each of the scales named below. Add any accidentals (sharps or naturals) which are necessary.

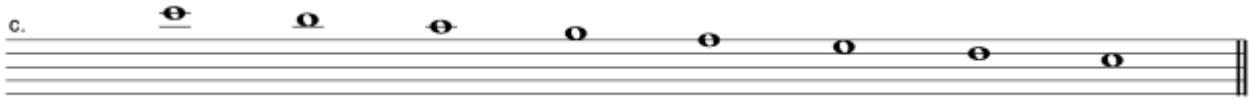
a) B harmonic minor



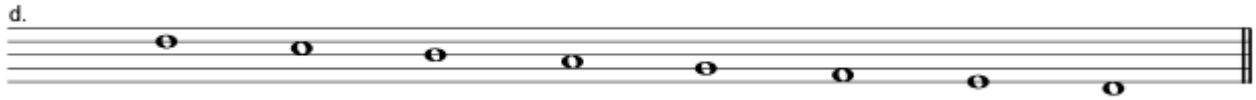
b) C melodic minor*



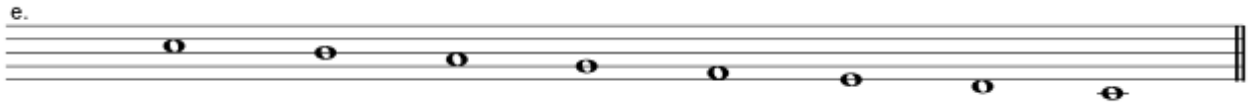
c) E major*



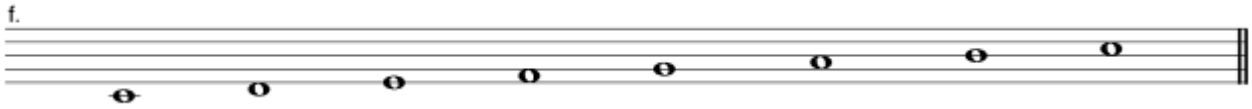
d) F melodic minor*



e) C# harmonic minor*



f) E melodic minor



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Exercise 4 - Writing Scales with Key Signatures

Write as semibreves (whole notes) the scales named below:

1. E major, descending, with key signature.*

2. F# harmonic minor, ascending, with key signature and any necessary accidentals.*

3. B melodic minor, ascending, with key signature and any necessary accidentals.

4. G harmonic minor descending, with key signature and any necessary accidentals.

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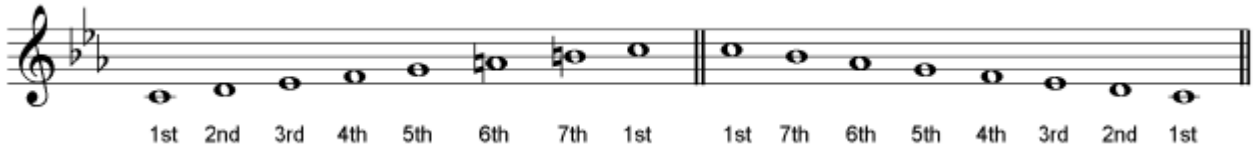
Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 5: Degrees of the Scale & Tonic Triads (ABRSM)

Degrees of the Scale

The degrees of the scale are numbers given to each note of the scale in order.
The numbers are based on the ascending scale:

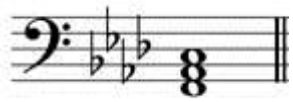


In a harmonic minor scale, the 7th degree of the scale is always raised by a semitone (half step). In a melodic minor scale, the 6th and 7th degrees of the scale are raised by a semitone in the ascending scale, but no degrees of the scale are changed in the descending scale.

Tonic Triads

The first degree of the scale is also known as the **tonic**.

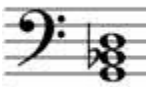
A tonic triad is a chord built up from the 1st, 3rd and 5th degrees of the scale.
For example, here is the tonic triad in F minor:



It's built on the tonic, F, with the 3rd degree of the scale, Ab, and the 5th, C.

Identifying Tonic Triads

You might be asked to **identify** a tonic triad. What key is this tonic triad?



First, work out the lowest note. The lowest note here is G.

Next, look at the middle note – does it occur in the major or minor form of the scale? The middle note here is Bb. Bb occurs in G minor, but not in G major. Therefore, this chord is the tonic triad in G minor.

If you are not sure whether it's major or minor, you can count the semitones (half steps) from the lowest note to the middle note. If there are 3 semitones, it's minor, if there are 4,

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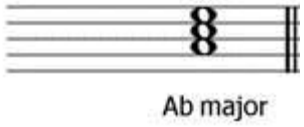
it's major. For example, G-Bb is 3 semitones (count G#-A-Bb), and G-B is 4 semitones (count G#-A-Bb-B).

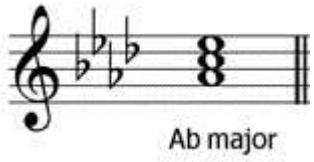
Adding a Clef and Key Signature/Accidentals to Tonic Triads

You might be asked to **add a clef and a key signature or accidentals** to a tonic triad. Which clef and key signature do we need to add to this tonic triad?

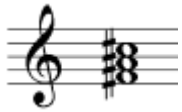


To make the lowest note an A, we need to add the treble clef. (If we put a bass clef, the lowest note would be a C.)

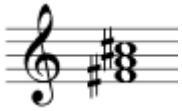
The key signature of Ab major has 4 flats, so we need to write in Bb, Eb, Ab and Db, in their correct positions:



If you are asked to add **accidentals** instead of a key signature, start by making a note of what the key signature is (e.g. Bb-Eb-Ab-Db for Ab major), then look at the triad and identify any notes which will need accidentals. In the Ab major triad, the Ab and Eb will need flats next to them, but the C does not need any accidentals.
If you don't have much space to write the accidentals, place the **highest** accidental close to the note on the stave, then off-set any lower accidentals to the left, so that they have enough room. For example, here is the tonic triad in F# minor, which needs F# and C#. If you write both of them close to the triad, they will overlap and become unreadable, making the A seem to have a sharp as well:



Move the lower sharp to the left, and they both become legible:



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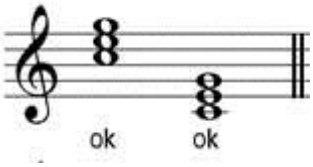
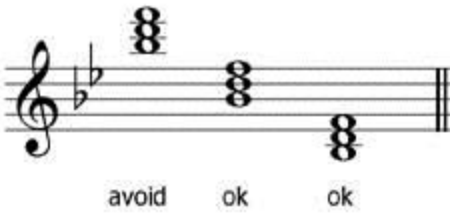
Which Octave?

It doesn’t matter which octave you write a tonic triad in. Here are two tonic triads in C major, in different octaves:



Try to avoid using lots of ledger lines though!



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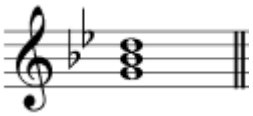
Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 5: Chords (Trinity)

Tonic Triads

The first degree of the scale is also known as the **tonic (or "doh")**. A tonic triad is a chord built up from the 1st, 3rd and 5th degrees of the scale.
For example, here is the tonic triad in G minor:



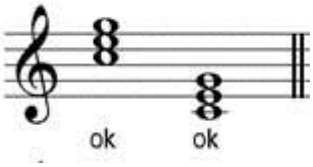
It's built on the tonic, G, with the 3rd degree of the scale, Bb, and the 5th, D.

The tonic triad is number **one**, because it's built from the **first** degree of the scale. So, in Roman numerals we say it is "I" or "i". We use capital letters for major triads, and lower-case letters for minor triads.

In lead sheets, you may see the chord symbol e.g. "Gm", which stands for "G minor".

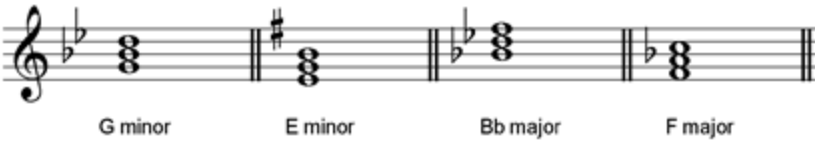
Which Register?

It doesn't matter which octave (or "register") you write a triad in. Try to avoid using lots of ledger lines though! Here are two triads in C major, in different octaves:



Inversions of the Triad

When the lowest note of the triad is the same as the chord's name, we say that the triad is in **root position**. The other two notes are each a 3rd higher than the lowest note. Here are some examples of tonic triads in root position:



If we change the order of the notes of the triad, so that the **middle** note becomes the **lowest** note, we say the triad is in **first inversion**. ("Inversion" means "turned upside

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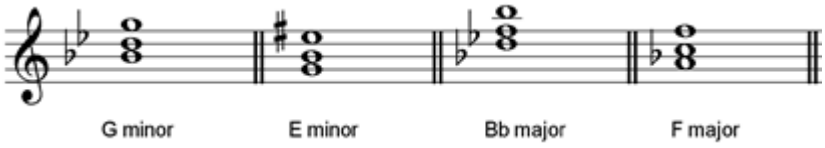
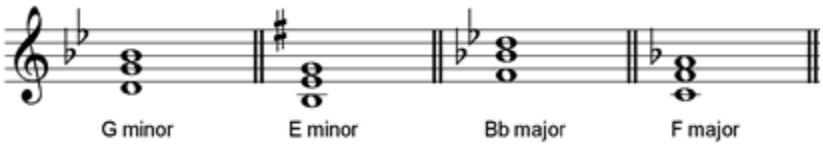
down”). Here are the same chords as above, but in their first inversions. The other two notes in the triad are now a 3rd, and a 4th higher than the lowest note.



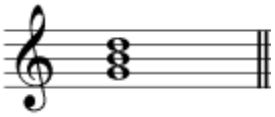
Important: When a chord is in an **inversion,** it is the **lowest** sounding note that we need to look at. You cannot tell an inversion by looking at the higher notes – only the lowest note (also called the “bass note”) counts.

When the **top** note from a root position triad is moved into the **lowest** position, the chord is in **second inversion**. Here are the same chords, but in second inversion. The intervals between the notes are now a 4th, and a 3rd.



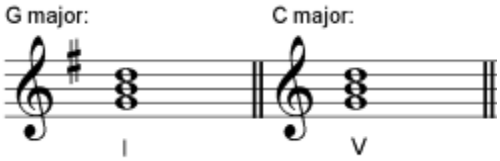
Dominant Triads

The fifth degree of the scale is also known as the **dominant (or “soh”)**.
A dominant triad is a chord built up from the 5th, 7th and 2nd degrees of the scale.
For example, in the key of C major, the 5th, 7th and 2nd degrees of the scale are G, B and D:



These three notes make a triad of G major. We can label this chord as V (with a capital V, which is the Roman numeral for 5), or simply as “G”, which means “G major”.

Remember that a triad of G major could also be called “chord I”. The Roman numeral name for a chord depends on the **key** the music is in. G major is chord I in the key of G major, but chord V in the key of C major:



In minor keys, we use the **harmonic** minor scale to build up the notes of the dominant triad.

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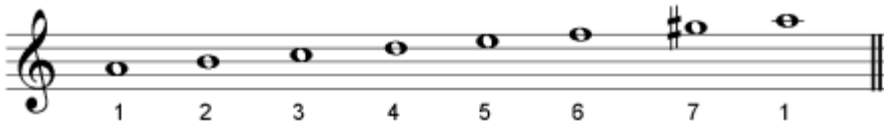
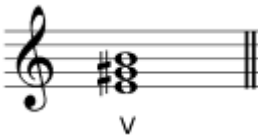
Here is the scale of A harmonic minor as an example:



The 5th, 7th and 2nd degrees of the scale are the notes E, G# and B, so the dominant triad in the key of A minor is the triad of E major:

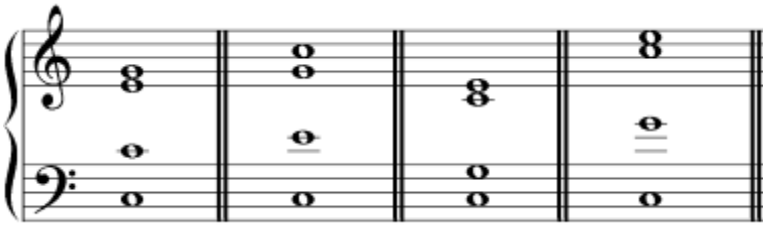


Because the 7th degree of the scale is raised up by a semitone in the harmonic minor scale, you will always need to add an **accidental** on to the middle note of a dominant triad, when it's in a minor key.

Four-Part Chords

A triad is a kind of **chord**. Triads always have only **three** notes in them, but "chords" can have any number of notes. One of the most common ways of writing chords is in **four parts**. Usually the root (or lowest note) of the triad is doubled up an octave higher, and added to the basic triad.
The top three notes of the chord can be written in any order. The **lowest** note of the chord should be the **root** of the triad if the chord is in root position.

Here are some examples of a C major root position chord, written in different ways. Notice that the lowest note is C in every case, but the order of the other three notes can be different:



These four-part chords are written using a system called **SATB**, which stands for "soprano, alto, tenor and bass". In this system, the chord is written on a grand staff (like a piano staff) with a treble and a bass clef stave joined together at the left with a bracket or brace.
On the treble clef we write the top two notes of the chord. The topmost note is called the "**soprano**" note, and the lower note is called the "**alto"** note. On the bass clef stave the topmost note is the "**tenor**" note, and the lowest note is the "**bass**" note. These four words can sometimes refer to the four main human singing voices, but they also refer to the general position of a note within a chord, even if the notes are played by **instruments** instead of voices.

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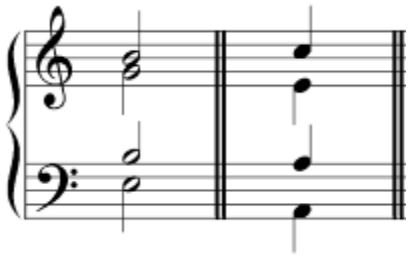
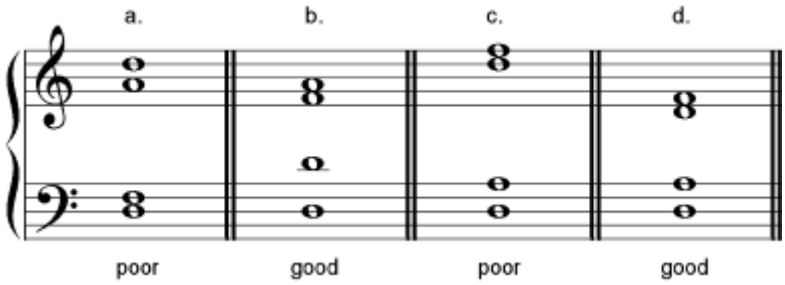
When you write out a chord in SATB style, you need to pay attention to the **stem direction** of the notes. Soprano and tenor notes are always written with the stems pointing **upwards**, and alto and bass notes always have their stems pointing downwards.



When you write out a chord in four-parts, it's also important to think about the **spacing** between the parts. If the bass and tenor parts are written close together, the chord can sound very "muddy" or indistinct. It is much better to write a wide space between the bass and tenor, and place the upper parts closer together. A good rule-of-thumb is keep the bass and tenor at least a 5th apart, and to keep the upper parts no more than one octave apart from the next note.



1. is poor because the gap between the tenor and alto is more than one octave, and the gap between bass and tenor is less than a 5th.
2. is good because the gap between bass and tenor is wide, and the gap between each pair of upper parts is narrow.
3. is poor because the gap between the tenor and alto is more than an octave.
4. is good because the gaps are spaced with the widest gap between the lowest two parts.

The Perfect Cadence

The **tonic** and **dominant** triads (or chords) work together in special ways in music. They are the two most important chords within music (in the Western world) because they are the chords which let us understand **what key** a piece of music is in, and help us to understand its **structure**.

Music is often organised into short "**phrases**" – these work a bit like sentences in language. A phrase is a musical idea with a clear start and end point. Phrases can be any length, but they are usually around 4 to 8 bars long.

Traditionally, the end of a phrase is always marked with something called a **cadence**. A cadence is a sequence of two particular chords – one followed by the other. The most common cadence is called the "**perfect** cadence", and this is the only one you need to

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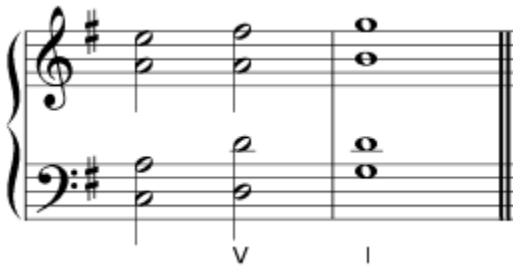
recognise for Trinity grade 3 music theory. You can think of a perfect cadence as similar to the “full stop” at the end of a sentence – it is a signal that the phrase has come to an end. A perfect cadence uses **chord V** (dominant), followed by **chord I** (tonic).

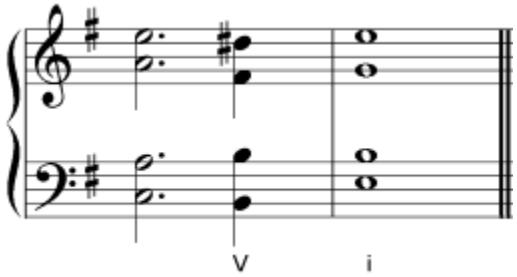
Here are some examples of perfect cadences.

Key: G major. Chord V (D major) is followed immediately by chord I (G major).

Notice how the 7th degree of the scale, F#, (also called the “leading note”) rises up a to the tonic note G in the same part.



Key: E minor. Chord V (B major) is followed immediately by chord i (E minor). The 7th degree of the scale, D#, is followed by the tonic note E in the same part.



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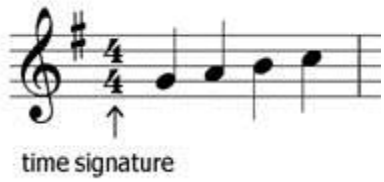
Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 6: Time Signatures

Quick Revision

A time signature is made up of two numbers, one written above the other. It's written only at the beginning of a piece of music, or within the music if the time signature changes in the middle of a piece. (It's not written on every new line, unlike the clef and key signature).



The top number tells you how many **beats** (not notes) to count in each bar.
The bottom number tells you what type of note to count.

Bottom number 4=crotchet beat
Bottom number 8=quaver beat
Bottom number 2=minim beat.

So, 4/4 tells you that there are **four crotchet** beats in each bar.

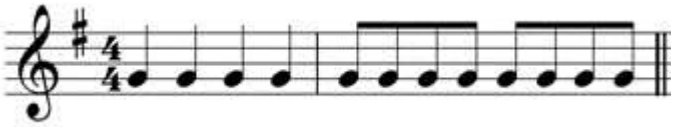
Simple Time Signatures

Up till now you have only learnt about **simple** time signatures. (Perhaps you didn't think they were very "simple" though!)
A **simple** time signature is one where:

- the top number in the time signature is 2, 3 or 4
- the main beat is divided into **two**
- the main beat is **not** a **dotted** note
- the bottom number of the time signature tells you what type of note is used for the **main beat**

.

For example, in 4/4 the main beat is a crotchet. If we want to divide the crotchet, we split it into **two quavers**:



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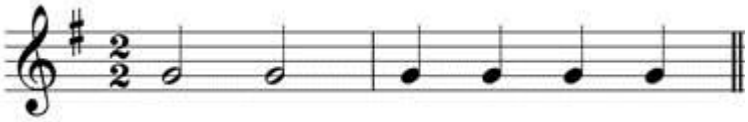
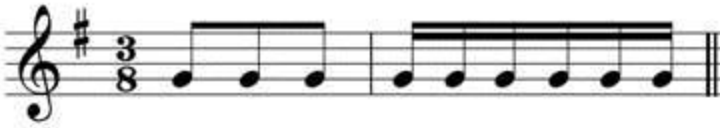
In 2/2, the main beat is a minim. We can split each one into **two crotchets:**



And in 3/8, the main beat is a quaver. We can split each one into **two semiquavers**:



Compound Time Signatures

Compound time signatures are new for grade three theory. A **compound** time signature is one where:

- the top number is 6, 9 or 12
- the main beat is divided into **three**
- the main beat is **always** a **dotted** note
- the bottom number shows you the **division** of the beat, not the main beat.

Here are the three compound time signatures you need to know for grade three theory:

6/8

The bottom number 8 tells us to count **quavers**, the top number tells us there should be **6** in a bar. But, the **main** beat is not quavers – because that would give us six beats in the bar. (There are always, 2, 3 or 4 beats per bar, or an irregular number which doesn't divide into 2, 3 or 4, such as 7).

We need to work out what note value is equal to **three** of the notes in the time signature: what are 3 quavers worth?

Three quavers = one dotted crotchet.

Each bar has two dotted crotchet beats.

In fact, the main beat in any /8 time is the **dotted crotchet.**

The quavers should always (whatever the time signature) be beamed to make complete beats whenever possible:

This grouping is wrong, because the quavers are grouped to make three beats, instead of

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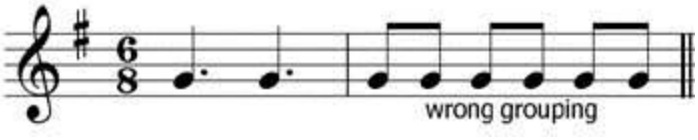
two. (This grouping would be fine for 3/4 time, which has three beats per bar).



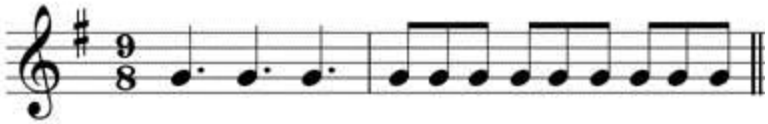
9/8

There are 9 quavers per bar.

Each group of three quavers makes one main beat, which is worth a dotted crotchet.

There are three dotted crotchet beats per bar.

Here you can see the dotted crotchet main beats, which are then each sub-divided into three quavers. The quavers are beamed in threes, to make up one complete beat each.

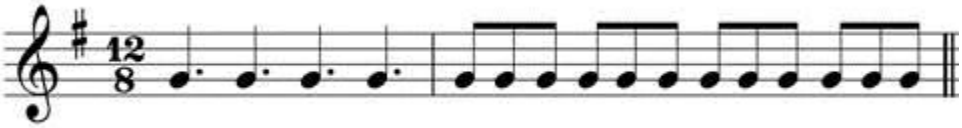


12/8

There are 12 quavers per bar.

Each group of three quavers makes one main beat, which is worth a dotted crotchet.

There are four dotted crotchet beats per bar. The quavers are beamed to make it easy to see that there are four beats per bar.



Remember! An undotted note is always split into two. A dotted note is always split into three.

Duple, Triple and Quadruple Time

All the time signatures that we've learnt so far can be described as **duple**, **triple** or **quadruple**.
These words refer to the **number of main beats** per bar.
In simple time, it's very easy to work out – just look at the **top** number.

2=duple, 3=triple and 4=quadruple.

- 2/2 and 2/4 are duple time

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- 3/2, 3/4 and 3/8 are triple time
- 4/2 and 4/4 are quadruple time

In compound time, you need to count the number of main beats, or you can divide the top number by 3.

- 6/8 is duple time (2 dotted crotchets per bar)
- 9/8 is triple time (3 dotted crotchets per bar)
- 12/8 is quadruple time (4 dotted crotchets per bar)

Here's all that information summarised in a table:

(Top Number)	Duple	Triple	Quadruple
Simple	2	3	4
Compound	6	9	12

(For a complete table of time signatures including examples, please see the time signature chart in our reference section).

Triplets

Triplets are introduced at Grade 3 in the Trinity syllabus but at grade 2 for ABRSM. Please see TRIPLETS for more information.

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Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 7: Adding Bar Lines or a Time Signature to a Melody

New at Grade Three

In your grade three music theory exam you might have to add a time signature to a short melody.

Although you also had this task at grade two, it's a bit harder at grade three.

This is partly because the time signatures 3/4 and 6/8 have the **same number** of quavers in them, so it's harder to tell them apart.

You'll also find the rhythms are a bit more complicated, which might include demisemiquavers, dotted notes and tied notes.

The time signatures you need to choose from at grade three are:

- 2/2, 3/2 (minim beat)
- 4/2 (minim beat, ABRSM only)
- 2/4, 3/4, 4/4 (crotchet beat)
- 3/8 (quaver beat)
- 6/8, 9/8, 12/8 (dotted crotchet beat – these are the compound time signatures)

Adding a Time Signature

To work out a time signature you need to discover two things:

1. What kind of beat is the main beat?
2. How many of these main beats are there per bar?

The easiest way to work out **what kind** of beat is the main beat, is to look for notes which are **beamed together**. (Obviously you need to look for a bar with quavers or semiquavers).

- Notes are beamed to add up to **one whole beat**. You need to work out what kind of note you need **one** of, to equal the notes which are beamed.
- When a new beat begins, a new beam begins too.
- Notes can also be beamed to add up to **one whole bar**, but only in **simple time**.

To work out **how many** main beats per bar there are, draw a circle around each group of notes that makes one full beat. Each circle has to contain the same value of notes overall. Then count the number of groups you circled. The number of circles in one bar is the number of beats per bar.

To work out the **time signature**, look at the information you have worked out.
The number of circles per bar will be 2, 3 or 4. This tells you whether the time signature is **duple**, **triple** or **quadruple**. Duple time signatures have either 2 or 6 as their top number. Triple time signatures have 3 or 9 as their top number. Quadruple time signatures have 4 or 12 as their top number.

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If each circle adds up to the value of a minim, the beat is a minim and the time signature will have a lower number 2. The top number will be 2, 3 or 4.

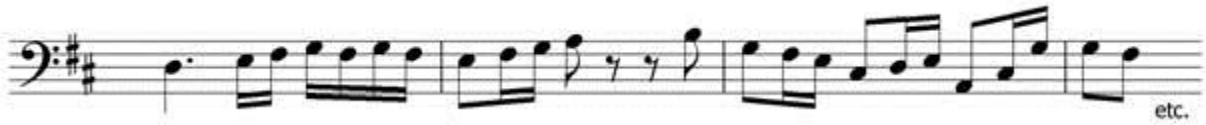
If each circle adds up to a crotchet, the lower number will be 4. The top number will be 2, 3 or 4.

If each circle adds up to a quaver, the lower number will be 8. The top number will be 3. (2/8 and 4/8 don't come up in the grade 3 exam).

If each circle adds up to a dotted crotchet, the lower number will be 8 (compound time). The top number will be 6, 9 or 12.

Here's an example question.

Add the time signature to this melody:



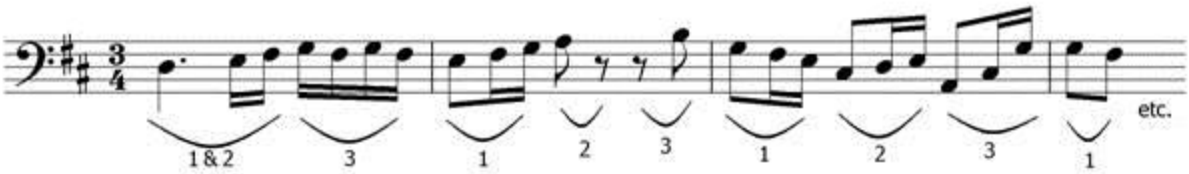
Look at the first bar and notice how the semiquavers are beamed. There are two joined together, and four joined together. Use the larger group.

Four semiquavers=1 crotchet. The first note of that group (the first G) must be the start of a new main beat, so the main beat is a crotchet. (If the main beat had been a dotted crotchet, the other two semiquavers would also be joined on, making six beamed semiquavers in total).

Look at bar 3. The quavers and semiquavers are again grouped together to add up to one crotchet each.

The main beat is therefore a crotchet beat.

Next, work out how many crotchets there are in each bar:



In each bar there are 3 crotchets' worth of beats.
(Notice that the last bar doesn't have a bar line at the end – it's not a complete bar, so it doesn't matter how many beats there are in it.)

Because the main beat is a crotchet, the lower number of the time signature is 4. Because there are **three** crotchets per bar, the top number is 3. The time signature is 3/4.

Here is another example:

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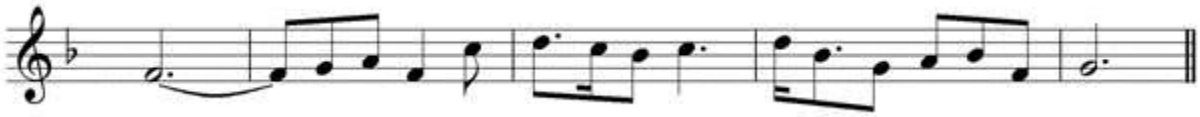
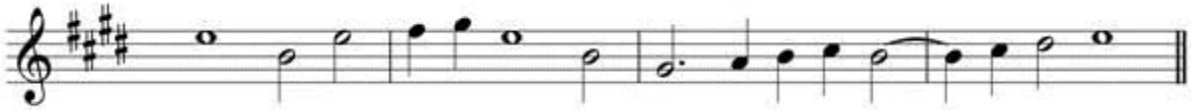


Choose bar 4 to look at first, as it has the most quavers/semiquavers.

- Remember that the notes are beamed to together to make **one** of something. What value do the beamed notes add up to? The answer is: the dotted crotchet. One dotted crotchet is worth the same as [semiquaver+dotted quaver+ quaver], and one dotted crotchet is worth the same as three quavers.
- It is **compound** duple time, because the main beat is a **dotted note**. The top number is 6.
- The bottom number is 8. (The bottom number is 8 because there the top number is 6, and there are 6 quavers' worth in each bar.)

(ABRSM only) Sometimes there will be no quavers or semiquavers to help you. If that is the case, you need to remember that there can only be 2, 3 or 4 beats per bar, no other number! (For grade 3 theory, that is!) Look at this example:



- The first bar contains **eight** crotchets.
- Crotchets can't be the main beat, because there are too many of them (8).
- Semibreves can't be the main beat, because semibreves are never used as the main beat (there are no time signatures with the lower number 1).
- So, minims are the main beat.
- There are four minims per bar.
- The time signature is 4/2.

Adding Bar Lines

You might be asked to add bar lines to a melody.

Look carefully at the time signature and write down the following information:

- How many beats
- Type of beats

Take your time – it's easy to make mistakes when you're in a rush!

Carefully count the notes, marking off each complete beat.

When you've reached the number of beats you need to make a complete bar, use your ruler and draw a neat bar line quite close to the first note of the next bar. Continue until you get to the end of the piece.

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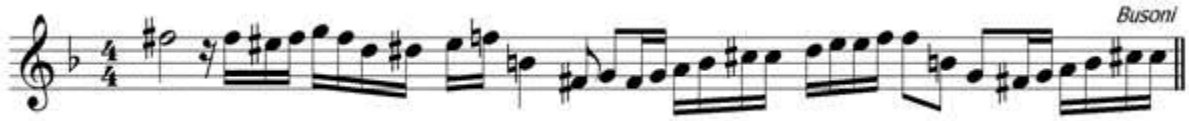
Pay **very careful** attention to the end of the piece.

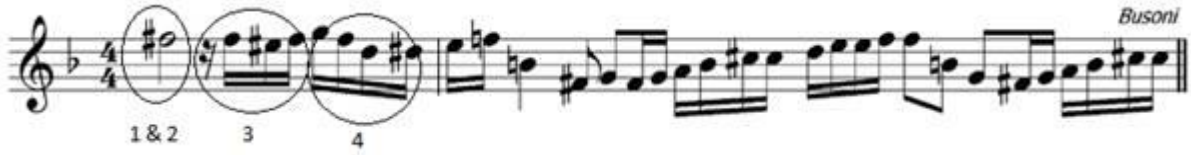
- If there is a bar line after the last note, the last bar **must** be complete.
- If there isn't a bar line, the last bar can contain **any number** of notes, (as long as it's not longer than a normal bar!) It might or might not be complete, so be careful.

Here's an example:

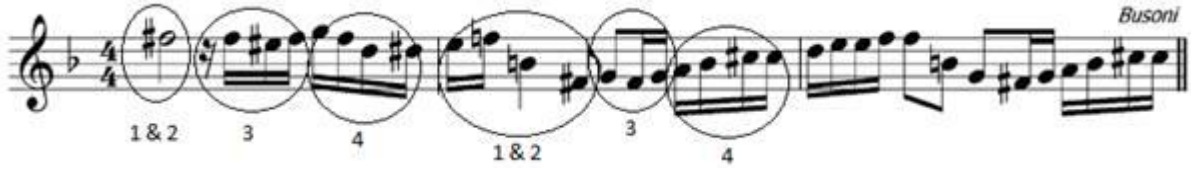


The time signature is 4/4, so each bar needs four crotchet beats.

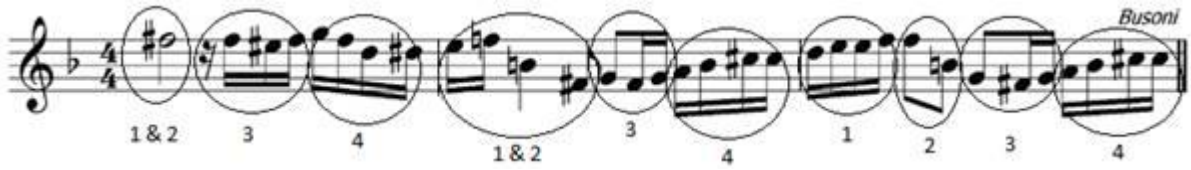
Count and mark off the crotchet beats until you reach four, then draw a bar line:



Repeat:



Double check the last bar – there is a bar line here so it should be a **complete** bar:



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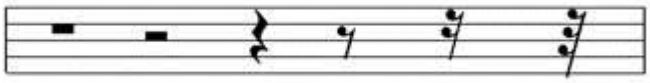
Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 8: Adding Rests & Beaming Notes in Groups

Rests

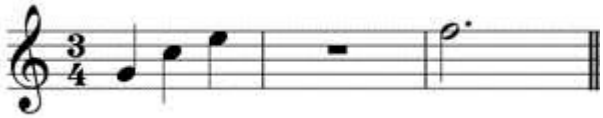
Here are the rests you need to know for the grade 3 music theory exam, in order of length, starting with the longest:

semibreve - minim - crotchet - quaver - semiquaver - demisemiquaver*



Rests can also be dotted.

The semibreve rest is also used as a **whole bar** rest, even when the value is worth less than four crotchets, for example in this 3/4 bar. It is placed in the centre of the bar.



The "whole bar" rest can be used in any time signature except for 4/2, where two semibreve rests are needed for one bar's silence.

Choosing the Right Rests

Although rests show silence, you still need to use the right rests according to the **time signature**, because rests are written to make the **main beats of the bar easy to see**.

- You will always need to start by working out the **type** and **number** of beats per bar, according to the time signature. Also work out what the next **sub-division** of the beat is. *E.g. 2/4 = two crotchets per bar, and each beat divides into 2 quavers, 6/8 = two dotted crotchets per bar, and each beat divides into 3 quavers.*

- Then use rests worth **one beat** or **two beats**, but two-beat rests may only be used on the **strong** beat of the bar. (In duple and triple time, this means the first beat of the bar only, and in quadruple time it means the first and third beats of the bar). You may also use the **whole bar rest** (see above).
- Don’t use **dotted** rests in **simple** time signatures (those with 2, 3 or 4 on top).
- If the rest you need is worth **less than one beat**, use smaller rests to complete the beat or sub-beat, before you do anything else.
- When completing a beat or a sub-beat, always put a longer note/rest before a shorter one, and not the other way round.

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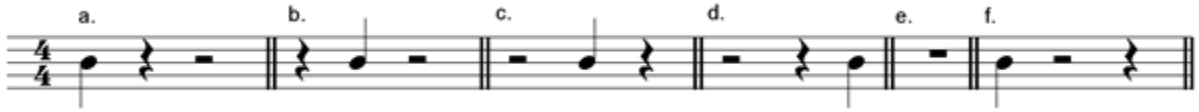
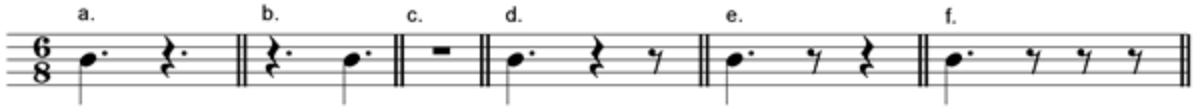
Examples

Rests worth one or two beats, or a whole bar:
Examples a-e are correct. Example f is wrong, because the two-beat rest has been put on the weak 2nd beat of the bar.

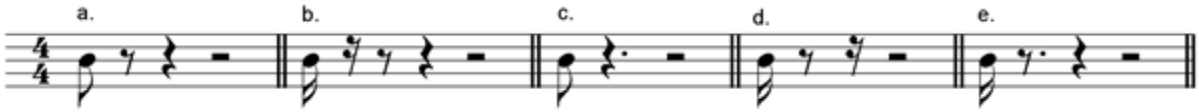


Examples a-c are correct. Example d is acceptable but used more rarely these days. Example e is incorrect, because the shorter rest is before the longer one. Example f is wrong, because we should use a rest worth one complete beat (a dotted crotchet).

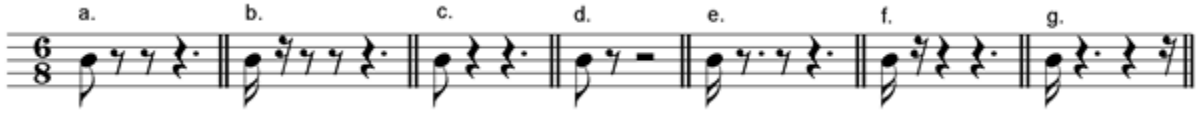


Rests worth less than one beat

Examples a and b are correct. Example c is wrong, because the first crotchet beat must be completed (with a quaver) before anything else, and we don't use dotted rests in simple time signatures. Example d is wrong, because the sub-beat (=quaver) should be completed before anything else. Example e is wrong, because we don't use dotted rests in simple time signatures.

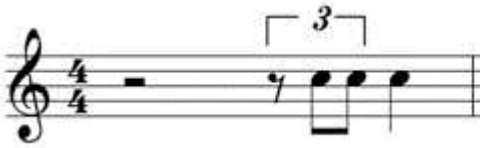


Examples a and b are correct. Example c is wrong, because the beat is balanced with a shorter part before a longer part (quaver note + crotchet rest). Example d is wrong, because a minim rest is never used in 6/8, as it is not worth one or two beats (it's worth one-and-a-third beats!) Example e is wrong, because we need to complete the sub-beat first (to make a quaver). Example f is wrong, because we have a longer rest (crotchet) after the shorter, first quaver sub-beat. Example g is wrong for many reasons!



Don't forget that rests can also be included as part of triplets.

The first two beats have a minim rest - the minim rest is allowed because it falls on the strong beat. The third beat is a triplet figure, with only two quavers. We need another quaver here to complete the triplet. The rest is written inside the square triplet brackets.



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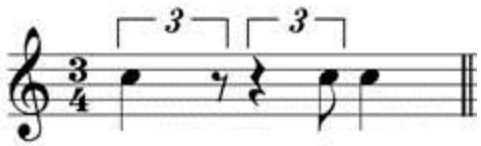
The first triplet figure is completed with a quaver rest. This makes up the first crotchet beat. The second triplet figure is completed with a crotchet rest.

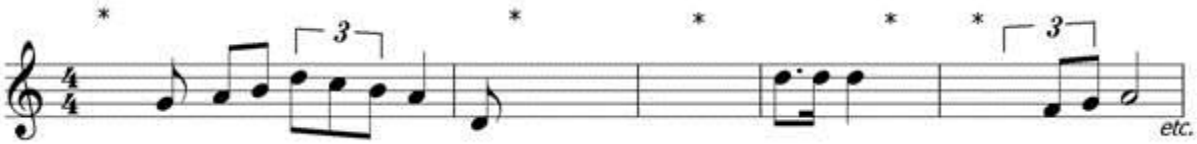


Adding Rests to a Melody

You may be asked to add the correct rest(s) at the places marked * to make each bar complete in a short melody.

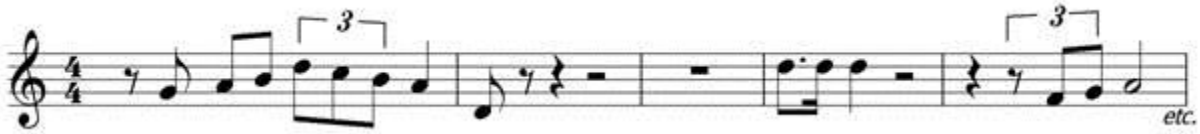
First, look at the **time signature**, and make a note of the **number** and **type** of beats per bar.
Write in the rests, making sure that you **complete main beats before anything else**, and that you don't write long rests on weak beats.

Here's an example:



- Bar 1: complete the first crotchet beat with one quaver.
- Bar 2: complete the first crotchet beat with a quaver rest, then write a crotchet rest to complete the second beat of the bar. Use a minim rest for beats 3 and 4 (ok because it falls on the strong 3rd beat).
- Bar 3: whole bar rest.
- Bar 4: finish the bar with a minim on the strong 3rd beat.
- Bar 5: crotchet rest to mark the first beat, quaver rest to complete the triplet on the second beat.

Here's the answer:



Grouping & Beaming Notes

A beam is the line that joins quavers, semiquavers or demisemiquavers together.

You might be asked to rewrite a passage with the notes correctly grouped, or beamed.

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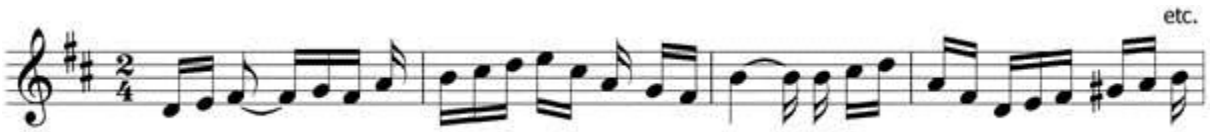
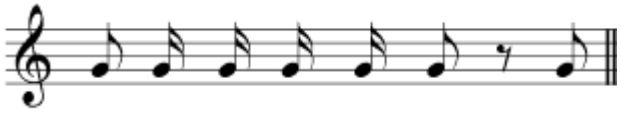
- Beam notes together in **complete beats**.
- Start a new beamed group on each main beat.
- Four quavers can (optionally) be beamed to equal a minim, as long as the group doesn't cross from a weak to a strong beat (e.g. beats 2-3 in 4/4 time).
- You might need to change the **direction of the stems** on some notes in the group.
- If you have several notes in a group where some go up and some go down, use the direction which would be correct for the note furthest from the middle line.
- The angle of beams follows the pattern of the music – if the music is rising in pitch, they slope upwards. If the music is falling in pitch they slope downwards. If the music stays at the same pitch, they are horizontal.

Here is a badly beamed passage:

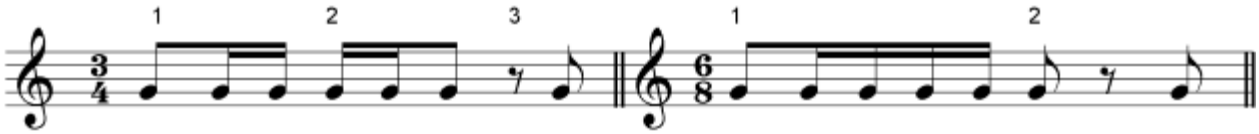


The time signature is 2/4, so we should have two crotchet beats per bar. The groups of quavers and semiquavers need to be beamed together to show this, and we also had to change the stem direction on a couple of notes:

Here is an example of how the **time signature affects beaming**. These notes will be beamed in a different way, depending on the time signature:



In 3/4 time, three beats per bar need to be shown. In 6/8 time, there are two beats per bar. Here is the correct beaming in each time signature:



(You could also beam together the last two quaver notes in the 6/8 bar, keeping the rest in the middle, if you prefer).

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Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 9: Intervals

Interval Number

We can describe an interval by using a **number**. For example, this interval is a **5th**, because there are five letter names between the lowest and the highest:

G-A-B-C-D = 5 letter names

At this grade, the lowest note is always the **tonic** (keynote), or first degree of the scale. (In later grades you'll find that the lower note can be anything at all!) To find the number of the interval, all you need to do is work out the degree of the scale.

D is the 5th degree of the scale of G major.

In the grade three music theory exam, you need to describe an interval with its number and also its **type**. You also need to know all the intervals in the new key signatures for this grade too, of course!

Interval Types

We will learn about three types of interval for grade three:

- Major intervals
- Minor intervals
- Perfect intervals

Major Keys

In a major key, all the intervals are either **major** or **perfect**. There are NO minor intervals in a major key (when the lowest note is the tonic).

Here is the scale of C major, showing each interval type when the lowest note is the tonic:

In all major scales, the unison, fourth, fifth and octave are **PERFECT** intervals. All the other intervals are **MAJOR**.

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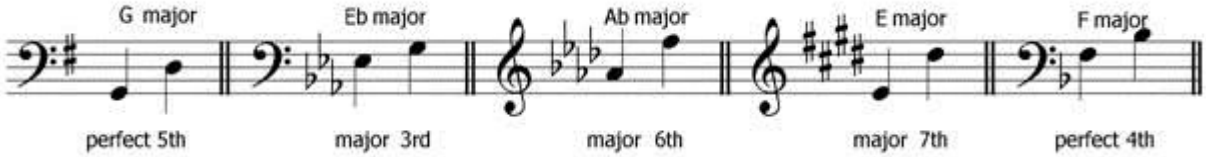
Here are some examples of intervals from other major keys:

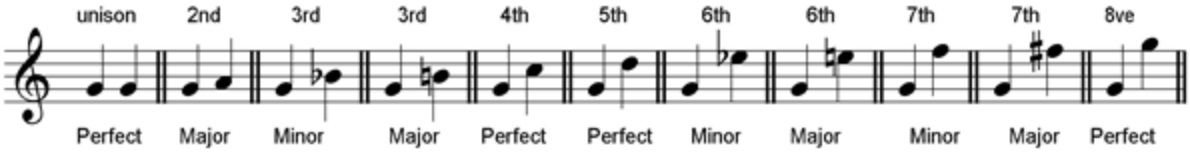


Minor Keys

In minor keys you will find major, perfect and also **minor** intervals. Minor intervals are always **one semitone smaller** than the major interval with the same number.
Intervals are based on the **harmonic** minor scale, or the **melodic** minor scale. Don't forget that this means the 6th and 7th degrees of the scale are sometimes raised by a semitone (half step)!

- Perfect intervals are the same in both major and minor keys: all unisons, 4ths, 5ths and octaves are **perfect**, whether the key is major or minor.
- The interval of a 2nd is **major** in both major and minor keys.
- In a minor key, the interval of 3rd is **minor**, whereas in a major key it is **major**.
- The intervals of a 6th and 7th are **major** in major keys, but can be **major or minor** in minor keys.

Here are the intervals built from the tonic of the G major and G minor scales.



The same pattern of major/minor/perfect intervals can be made from any tonic starting note.

You can see that only three intervals are different, between the major and minor versions of the scale - the 3rd, 6th and 7th.

Intervals at a Glance:

Number from Tonic	Major Scale Type	Minor Harmonic Type	Minor Melodic Type
Unison	Perfect	Perfect	Perfect
2nd	Major	Major	Major
3rd	Major	***Minor***	***Minor***
4th	Perfect	Perfect	Perfect
5th	Perfect	Perfect	Perfect
6th	Major	Minor	***Major or minor***
7th	Major	Major	***Major or minor***

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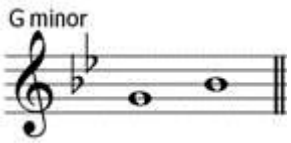
Octave	Perfect	Perfect	Perfect

Describing Intervals

You will probably get a question asking you to describe some intervals by giving the **type** and **number**, like this:



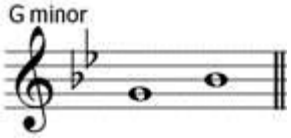
Type ……
Number ……

- Notice that they **key** is given to you – this interval is in G minor.
- The lowest note will always be the tonic.

Starting at the lower note, count how many letter names of notes there are up to the higher one.

G-A-Bb = three notes.

This interval is a **third**. The key is **minor**, so it will be **minor third** (remember that 3rds and 6ths are minor intervals in minor keys).



Type: <u>minor</u>
Number: <u>third</u>

Intervals can be written vertically ("harmonic") or horizontally ("melodic").

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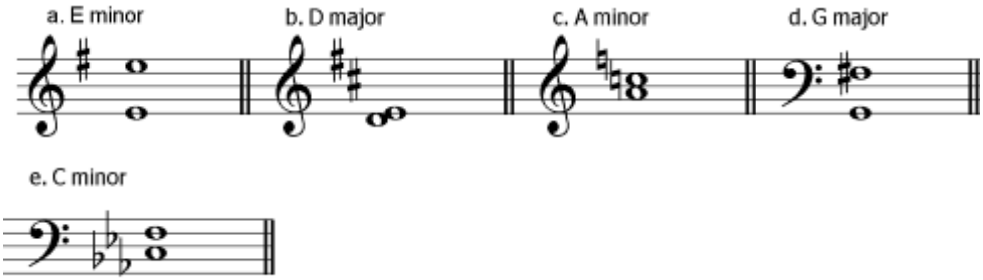
Grade 3 Music Theory- Lesson 9. Intervals: Exercises

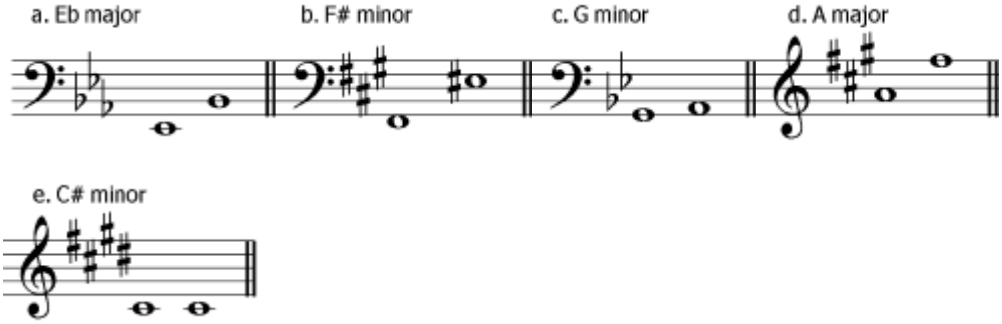
Exercise 1 - Describing Harmonic Intervals

Describe each of these harmonic intervals, giving the type and number (e.g. minor 3rd, perfect 8ve). The keys are named and in each case the lower note is the key note (tonic).



Exercise 2 - Describing Melodic Intervals

Describe each of these melodic intervals, giving the type and number (e.g. minor 3rd, perfect 8ve). The keys are named and in each case the lower note is the key note (tonic).



Exercise 3- Describing Intervals (Mixed)

Describe each of these intervals, giving the type and number (e.g. minor 3rd, perfect 8ve). Also say whether the interval is **melodic** or **harmonic**. The keys are named and in each case the lower note is the key note (tonic).

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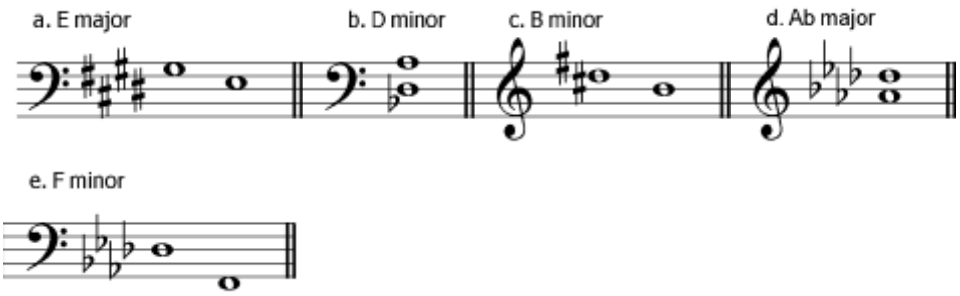
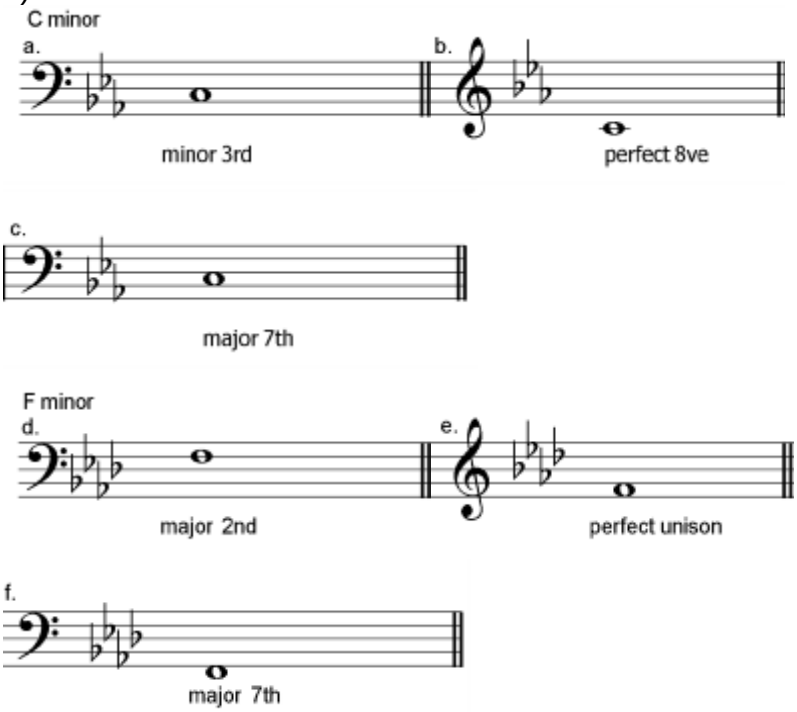


Exercise 2 - Writing Harmonic Intervals

Above each of these notes, write a higher note to form the named harmonic interval. The key is given.

F# minor
a)



Exercise - Writing Melodic Intervals

After each of these notes, write a higher note to form the named melodic interval. The key is given.

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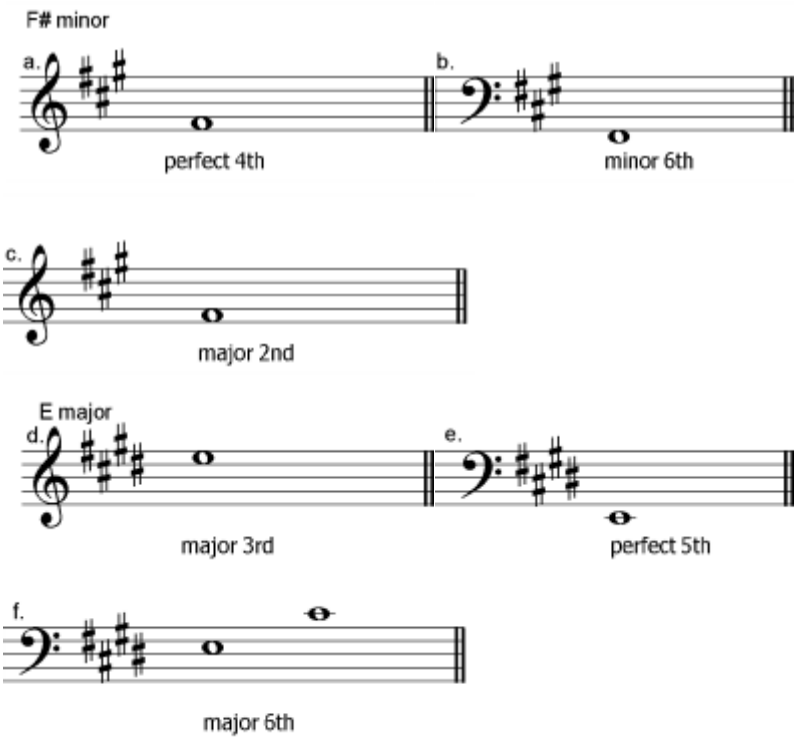

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Grade Three Music Theory - Lesson 10: Transposition

In the grade three music theory exam, you might have to transpose a short melody, **at the octave, between clefs**. What does that mean, exactly?!

Transpose at the Octave

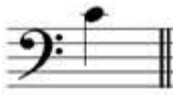
Transpose means "write in another place". Transposed music can be written in a different clef, different key, or different octave, or any combination of these! But you won't have to transpose music into another **key** at grade 3 - that comes later. At this grade, you need to transpose between **clefs**, **at the octave**.
"At the octave" means that the music is transposed either **up** eight notes or **down** eight notes. For example, we can transpose this C:

down an octave (8 notes), to this C:

Between Clefs

This means that we change the clef used – from treble to bass or the other way round. For example, we can transpose the same C:

down an octave AND put it into the bass clef:



C4

Middle C is known as **C4**. The C above it is C5, and the C below it is C3. You don’t need to know this for your grade three music theory exam, but it’s a really useful way of referring to notes by octave, when you are talking about them, so it’s worth learning!

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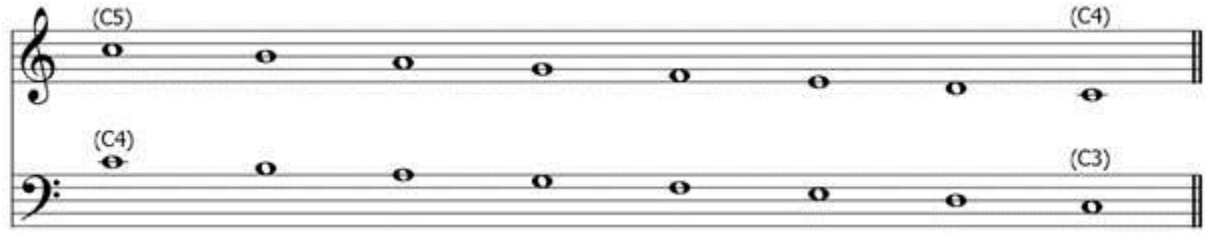
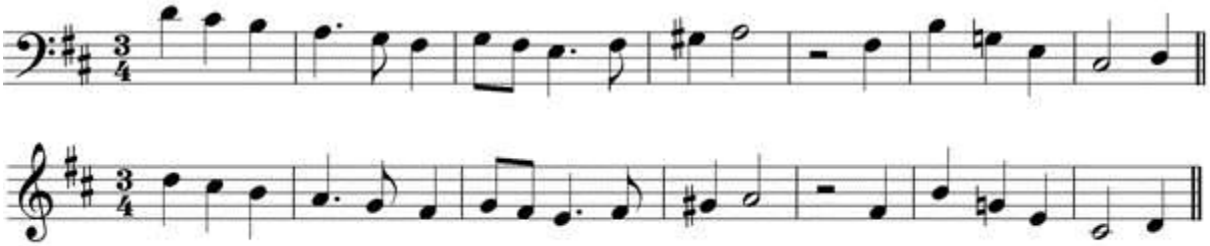
Transposition Examples

Here is the scale of C major in the treble clef, transposed **at the octave and to the bass clef**:



Here's a short melody transposed **at the octave and to the treble clef**:



How to Transpose

If you get a transposition question in the exam, you'll be told which clef you need to transpose into.

The new clef will already be in place.

You will sometimes have to add the key signature, time signature and bar lines, (but sometimes they are already written for you).

Then you need to add the **notes** and **rests**, as well as any **accidentals**, and also any other things such as **dynamics**, **articulation** (e.g. staccato) and **phrasing** marks.

- Don't rush the first note. Triple check you've got the first note right, and all the others will follow naturally.
- Look at clef and the first note – make sure you're not thinking in treble clef, when in fact it's bass (and vice versa!) What note is it?
- Work which octave the first note is in. **Is it above or below middle C?**
- Carefully write the new first note, one octave higher (or lower, depending on the question), immediately below the original.
- Continue with the rest of the notes.
- Write all the notes and rests **directly** below the original ones. This will make sure that you don't run out of space and that the notes are aligned properly.
- Use a ruler to draw the stems and beams.
- Make an effort to be neat. You will lose marks if the examiner can't read what you've put.
- Make sure you haven't forgotten to copy any of the phrasing or dynamics markings.

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Grade 3 Music Theory - Lesson 11: Rewriting with Different Time Values

What is Rewriting?

We can rewrite a melody using different value notes, without changing the rhythm. For example, here's a rhythm in 3/4:

And here's the same rhythm in 3/2:

The rhythm itself hasn't changed - only the type of note used as the **main beat** has changed.

The time signature changes – but only the **lower number**. This is because we have kept the same **number** of beats per bar (3), and we have only changed the **type** of beat from a crotchet (quarter note) in the first example, to a minim (half note) in the second example.
A minim (half note) is worth two crotchets (quarters), so all the notes in the second example are **twice the value** of those in the first one. The notes in the first example are **half the value**.
Rhythms written at **twice** the value use **slower** note values.
Be careful! If we write a rhythm in notes of **half** the value, we **double** the bottom number. If we write a rhythm in notes of **twice** the value, we **halve** the bottom number. This might seem a little strange at first!

Table of Time Signatures

For the grade three exam, you only need to know about these time signatures for this question:

Twice the Value	Original Time Signature	Half the Value
3/4	3/8	-
2/2	2/4	-

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3/2	3/4	3/8
4/2	4/4	-
-	2/2	2/4
-	3/2	3/4
-	4/2	4/4

(Compound time signatures will not come up in this part of the exam.)

Table of Note Durations

Twice the Value	Original Note	Half the Value
		-
-		

Dotted notes don’t need any special treatment. Just copy the dot over to the new note value.

Table of Rest Durations

Twice the Value	Original Rest	Half the Value
		-

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-		

How to Rewrite with New Note Values

- Put the new time signature in first.
- On a piece of rough paper, draw a table showing the new note values you'll need. (For example, if you are rewriting at half the value, write ♩ => ♪. Use this for reference as you do the question – it will help to avoid mistakes.
- Write each new note **directly** under each original note, so that you don't run out of space.
- Draw note stems and bar lines with a ruler.
- Don't forget to add any accidentals.
- Don't forget to beam quavers (eighth notes) and semiquavers (sixteenth notes) together.
- Check your work by carefully counting up the beats in each bar.

Grade 3 Music Theory - Lesson 12: Completing a Rhythm [Archived Lesson]

Please note: rhythm writing was removed from the grade 3 syllabus in January 2018.

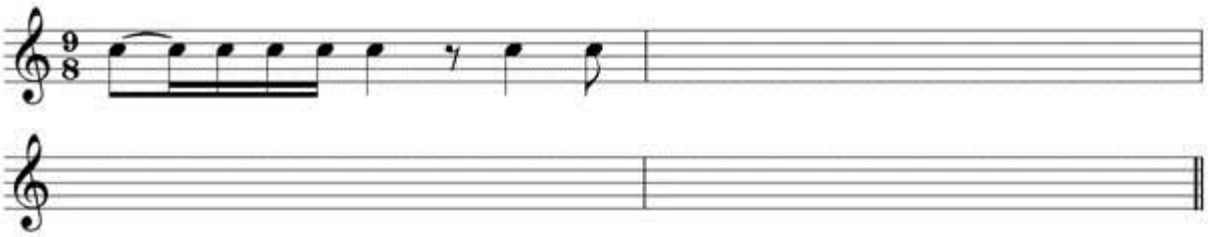
If you are preparing for the ABRSM grade 3 music theory exam, this is a question which you must prepare thoroughly, because it's always included and it's worth ten points, or 10% of the whole exam!

You need to write a **complete** four-bar rhythm using the given opening.
You'll be given one complete bar including the time signature, so you need to write **three** more bars.

You don't need to write a tune, only the rhythm.

Here's an example:

Write a complete four-bar rhythm in 9/8 time using the given opening.



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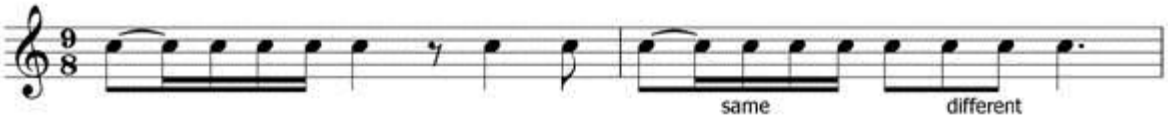
Tips

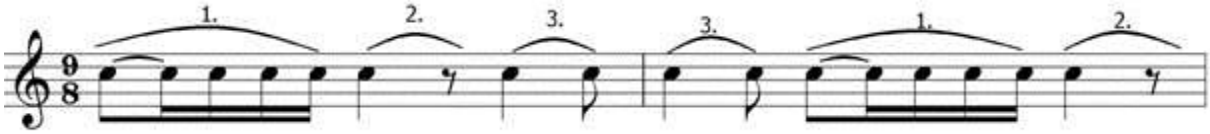
1. Notice the time signature and make sure that each bar you write has the right number of beats.
2. Check that beamed notes (quavers, semiquavers and demisemiquavers) (8ths/16ths/32nds) are grouped correctly.
3. Don't just repeat exactly what you already have in any bar.
4. Don't write something that's completely different to any other bar.
   Tips one and two are straightforward, but tips three and four are a little bit more difficult to get right. You need to write something which is **similar** to bar one, but not **the same** and not **very different**. It can be hard to get that right, so make sure you do lots of practice!

   Some ways you can achieve this:

- As you write each bar, keep **some** of the rhythmic patterns from the previous bar, but not all of them. You can change half to three quarters of the bar, for example:



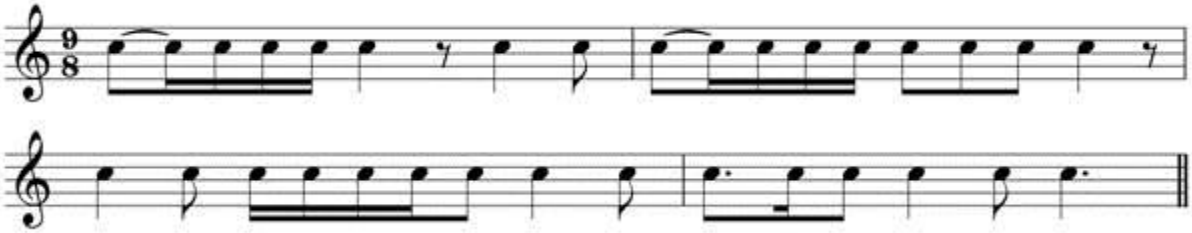
- Change the order of some of the groups of notes:



(The groups are numbered to show you how the order has changed.)

- Don't write things like lots of triplets, dotted/tied notes or syncopation **UNLESS** there were some in the first bar. You need to keep the character of the rhythm the same all the way through.
- Don't feel that you have to "show off" by writing every single different note value/rests, or anything else. It's more important to **keep the character** of the rhythm.
- Make sure any long notes fall **on the beat** (see lesson 8 for more on this).
- Use a reasonably long note to end the composition: don't end on a quaver, semiquaver or demisemiquaver (8th, 16th or 32nd note).

Here's a possible answer to the above question:



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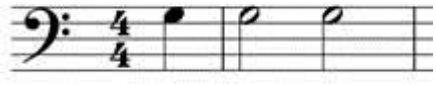
Notice how the same patterns get reused, but not in exactly the same way. We used a dotted note in the 4th bar, but it’s not a “new” rhythm – it’s the same value as the tied quaver (8th) + semiquaver (16th) in bars 1 and 2.

Dealing with Upbeats

An "upbeat" is a part of the rhythm which occurs before bar 1. If the piece starts on an upbeat, the first bar will **not** be complete. For example, this rhythm in 4/4 starts on an upbeat - there is just one crotchet (quarter note) in the first bar:



The second G falls on the strong beat - the first beat of bar 1. It is played with a stronger stress than the first G. Think of the word "po***ta***to" - the stress falls on the second syllable of the word. If you set the word "potato" to music, you'd use an upbeat for the syllable "po-", so that "-ta-" falls on the strong beat of the bar. Even when there are no words set to music, rhythms still contain stresses in the same way.
If there is an upbeat, you must make sure the last bar of your piece is also **incomplete.**

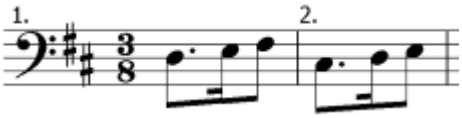
- The first bar and the last bar **added together** should make one complete bar. In our example, our last bar should contain 3 beats (not 4).

Finding Similarities and Differences

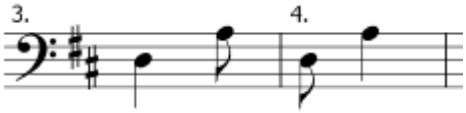
You might be asked to describe the similarities or differences between two sections of the music. You need to look at:

- The melody
- The rhythm
- The dynamics and phrasing

For example, you might see two bars which have the same rhythm, but a different melody:



the same melody notes, but a different rhythm:



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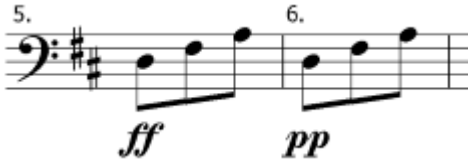
the same melody and rhythm, but different dynamics:



You should try to describe with a little bit of detail what the similarities and differences are.

For example:

Bars 1-2
Similarity: Both bars use a rhythm of dotted quaver (8th note), semiquaver (16th note), quaver (8th note).
Difference: In bar 2 the melody is a scale step lower.

Bars 3-4
Similarity: Both bars use a leap of a perfect 5th D-A as the melody notes.
Difference: The rhythm is reversed in bar 2.

Bars 5-6
Similarity: Both bars have the same melody and rhythm.
Difference: The dynamics change from fortissimo in bar 5 to pianissimo in bar 6.

Counting Patterns

You might have to count the number of times you see:

- a certain rhythm
- bars which contain all the notes of the tonic triad
- a certain note (e.g. 3rd degree of the scale)

This is a very easy question! Just make sure you don't rush it and miss something.

Marking Phrases

You might have to mark out the phrases in the score with a square bracket. The first one will be done for you.

- Phrases will normally (but not always) be the same number of bars in length (often four times two-bar phrases in an 8 bar piece).
- Phrase marks don't include rests (unless they are in the middle of the phrase)
- Use a ruler to draw the brackets.
- Use clues like crescendos to help you understand which notes would be kept together in the same phrase.

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Grade 3 Music Theory - Lesson 14: Finding Deliberate Mistakes

In the ABRSM Grade 3 Music Theory Exam, you might be given a short piece of music with about 5 deliberate mistakes in it. You need to rewrite the whole melody correctly on the given stave.

The kinds of mistake you need to look for include:

- Wrongly placed clef
- Wrongly placed sharps/flats in the key signature
- Upside down time signature
- Upside down symbols, e.g. pause mark
- Accidentals placed on the wrong side of the note
- Accidentals placed on the wrong line/space
- Stems pointing in the wrong direction

Here's an example:

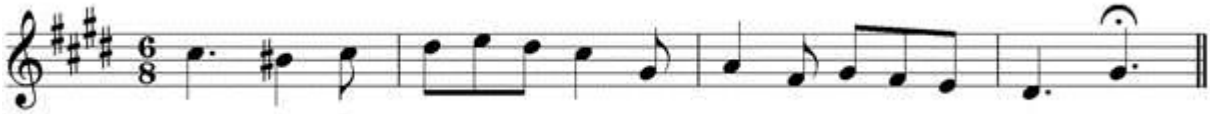
The following passage contains **five** deliberate mistakes. Rewrite it correctly on the given stave.

- Find all the mistakes BEFORE you start writing out the melody!
- Write the notes directly underneath the originals, so that you don't run out of space.
- Use a ruler to draw note stems and beams.

The five mistakes in this passage are:

- The clef is in the wrong position (the curly middle bit needs to circle the G line)
- The time signature is upside down
- In bar 1, the sharp is on the space for A, instead of on the line for B.
- In bar 2, the quaver G should have its stem pointing upwards (because it's below the middle line of the stave).
- In bar 4, the pause symbol is upside down. (Pauses are written that way up if they are written **under** the stave.

Here is the same melody, rewritten with the mistakes corrected:



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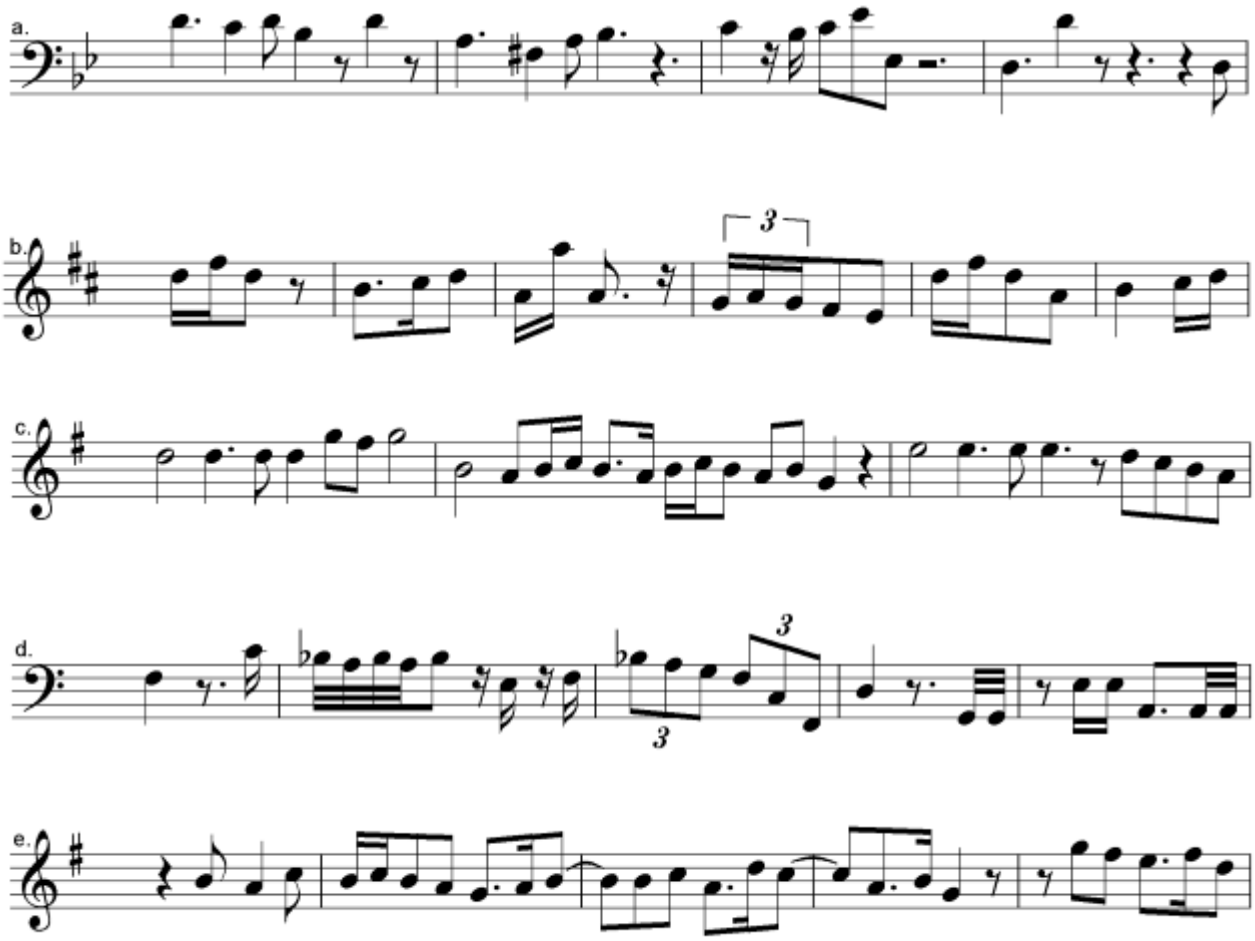
Grade Three Music Theory - Practice Exam (Updated)

ABRSM Syllabus (2018+)

Answer all questions. Write your answers neatly and clearly, otherwise you may lose marks. You have 1 hour and 30 minutes.
Hover your mouse over the staves or lightbulbs to reveal the answers. (Tap on mobile devices).

Scoring: 66/100=Pass, 80/100=Merit and 90/100=Distinction

1. Add the time signature to each of these five melodies. (10 points)



2. Add the correct rest(s) in the places marked with a star. (10 points)

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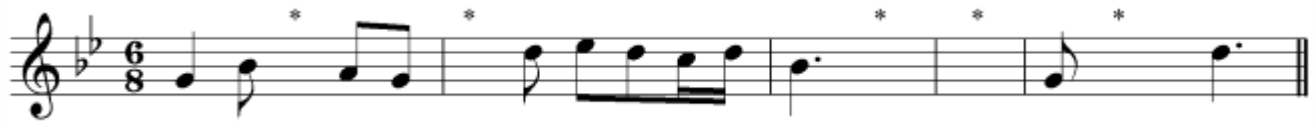
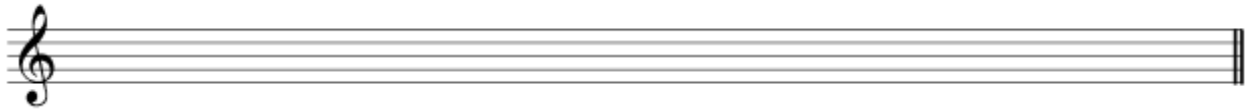
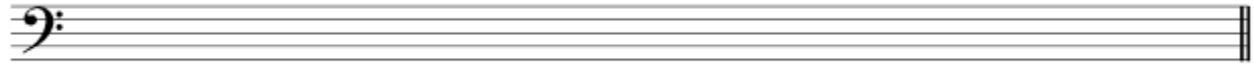


3. Write as semibreves (whole-notes) the scales named below. (10 points)

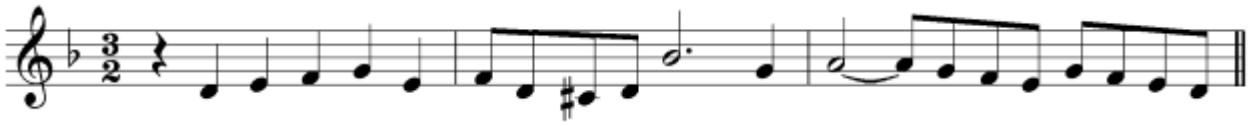
a) E major, descending, with key signature



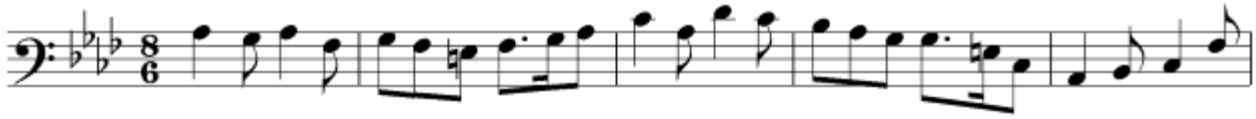
b) F# melodic minor, ascending, without key signature but including any necessary sharp or flat signs.



4. Rewrite this melody using notes and rests of *half the value*. Remember to put in the new time signature. (10 points)



5(a) The following passage contains *five* deliberate mistakes. Rewrite it correctly. (10 points)



5(b) Name the degree of the scale (e.g. 4th, 5th) of the highest note. The key is F minor.

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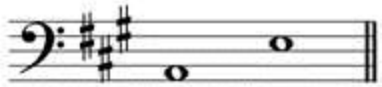
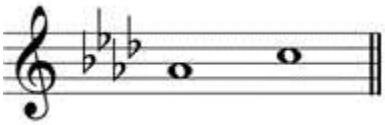
6. Describe each of these melodic intervals, giving the type and number (e.g. minor 3rd, perfect 5th). The keys are named, and in each case the lower note is the key note (tonic). (10 points)

a. A major



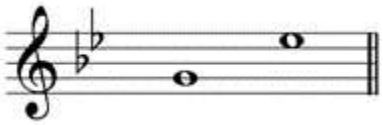
Type: Number:

b. Ab major



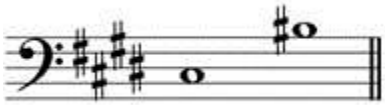
Type: Number:

c. G minor



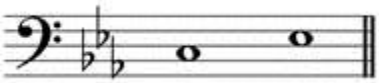
Type: Number:

d. C# minor



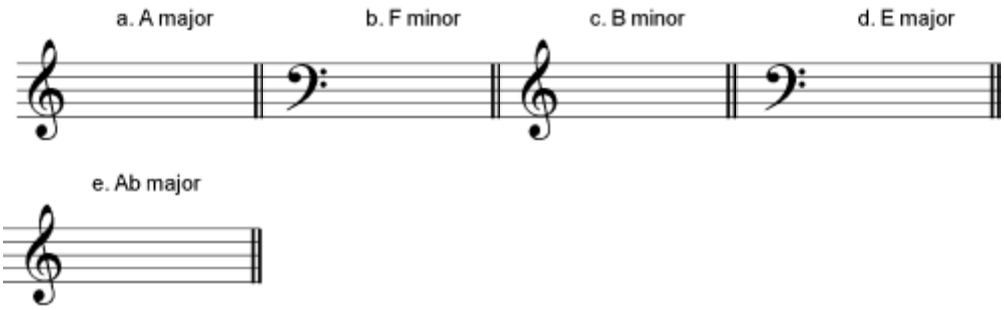
Type: Number:

e. C minor



Type: Number:

7. Write the key signature and tonic triad of each of these keys. (10 points)



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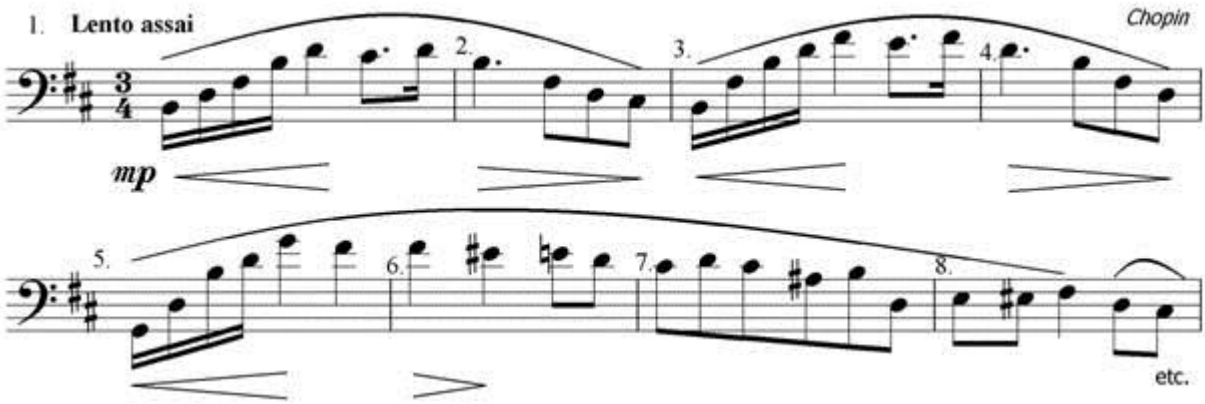
8. This melody is by Chopin. Look at it and answer the questions below.



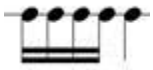
A. (10 points)

(i) Give the meaning of each of these.

1. Lento assai
2.
3. *mp*
4.

(ii) Describe the time signature as simple/compound
and duple/triple/quadruple

B. (10 points)

(i) How many times does the rhythm  occur?

(ii) Name a minor key in which all the notes of bar 8 can be found.

(iii) Name one similarity and one difference between bars 1 and 3.

Similarity

Difference

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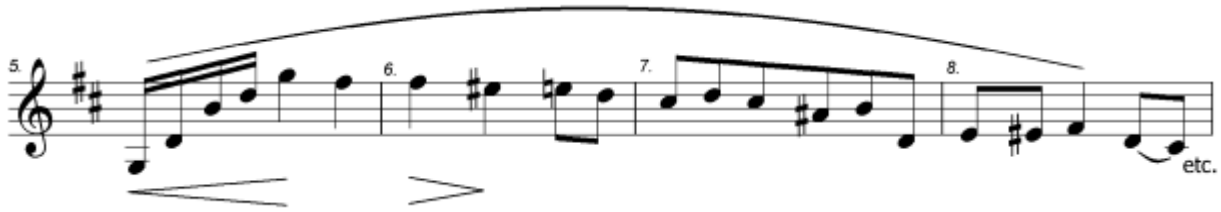
(iv) Answer TRUE or UNTRUE to the following sentence:
Every bar contains at least one note belonging to the tonic triad of B minor.

C. Write out the melody from bar 5 to the end of the music *an octave higher*, using the treble clef as shown. (10 points)



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